

RECLAIMING KNOWLEDGE

Decolonial Methodologies from the Global South



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This book is dedicated to all communities across the Global South who continue to resist the erasure of their knowledge, their lands, and their ways of being, and to the scholars, practitioners, and activists, named and unnamed, who stand with them.

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FOREWORD

Prof. Wanjiku Mukabi Kabira

Director, African Women's Studies Centre, University of Nairobi

There is a question that has stayed with me for close to five decades of working with oral literature across the African continent: narratives, proverbs, myths and epics such as that of Sundiata from Old Mali and Shaka the Zulu from South Africa; literatures from West, South, Northern Africa and of course our East Africa, as well as literature of the African Diaspora including African American literature and Caribbean literature. In the last two decades of my career, I have focused on women's knowledge and African feminist knowledge creation, in addition to working with the institutions that decide on what counts as scholarship in Africa. For these institutions, the simple questions we want to ask are: Who determines what knowledge is created in the Global South? Who decides which journals are scientific and acceptable for academic scholarship? Who decides the citation indices? Who determines the impact of journals and the funding bodies that determine which ideas travel and which remain local, which voices are amplified and which are muted, only to be footnoted? We find that universities and other academic institutions keep looking towards the West for legitimacy. This must end!

I have spent much of my scholarly life working with materials that the western academic tradition had for long classified as minor or nonexistent: oral narratives, women's testimonies, community memory, storytelling practice, and other literatures marginalised by western scholarship, including works by African scholars such as Chinua Achebe, Ngugi wa Thiong'o, Okot p'Bitek, Wole Soyinka, Micere Mugo, Grace Ogot, Christopher Okigbo and many others, for whom publishers like the great Henry Chakava of East African Publishers had to fight to put them in the global market. Similarly, these writers had to fight for their texts to be included in school syllabi in Africa. When Kabebe wa Wanyaroco, the storyteller in *The Oral Artist* (Kabira, 1983), and Wanjira wa Rukenya in *Reclaiming My Dreams* (Kabira & Waita, 2010) performed narratives, they were not producing content for an archive. They were doing something with and for the people present, orienting them, questioning them, holding the community's understanding of itself. That kind of knowledge does not fit neatly into a peer-reviewed article, and the difficulty of the fit is not a deficiency in the knowledge.

The architecture of knowledge production that Africa inherited from the colonial period did not come without instructions. It came with a very clear set of decisions about whose experience generates theory and whose experience generates data. Those decisions have proven remarkably durable. Moreover, before the colonial period, what we call "classical thinkers" did not see Africa as a place where knowledge would be created. In relation to women specifically, the theoretical and philosophical basis of women's

oppression has throughout history been legitimised by ideas advanced by the same western scholars, Plato and Aristotle among them, and has continued to guide most research theories, methodologies, and scholarship in general.

This volume is a direct engagement with that durability. *Reclaiming Knowledge: Decolonial Methodologies from the Global South* does not ask for inclusion in existing structures. It questions the structures themselves, their philosophical foundations, their institutional habits, their capacity to recognise what they routinely exclude. That is a harder task than it sounds, and it is to the credit of the editor and contributors that they pursue it with patience and specificity rather than with the broad gestures that often substitute for analysis in this field. What the chapters in this volume demonstrate, across very different contexts, is precisely that difficulty, and what becomes possible when researchers refuse to resolve it by simply discarding what does not fit. The Afro-Colombian women whose vivencias animate Chapter 2 carry knowledge of survival, resistance, and collective reconstitution that no external methodology could produce and no external validation should be required to authorise. These writers are breaking the ceiling of scholarship and research methods that have marginalised knowledge creation, particularly from women, and excluded women's views and perspectives from knowledge creation. The Indigenous cartographers of northeastern Brazil in Chapter 3 are not illustrating a concept developed elsewhere; they are generating one. The Ubuntu framework engaged in Chapter 1 is not a metaphor borrowed to make African content feel more African. It is a philosophical system with its own epistemological rigour, and it is treated as such in this book.

This matters because the habit of treating African, African Diaspora, and Latin American knowledge traditions as illustration rather than as sources of knowledge has been persistent and costly. Communities with sophisticated understandings of art, spirituality, ecology, governance, health, trade, indigenous technologies and engineering systems, resource management practices, justice systems, education and social organisation, among other areas, have been studied at length, their knowledge gathered and carried elsewhere, while remaining peripheral to the very theoretical conversations their own realities could have generated and should have shaped. The people in these communities have been denied the opportunity to name their world. What was built from their knowledge is rarely acknowledged as having come from them.

I want to say something about methodology directly, because it is central to what this book argues and it is a question I have grappled with throughout my career. Methodology is not a technical matter. It is an ethical one. The choices a researcher makes about how to gather knowledge, from whom, under what conditions, and toward what ends, are choices about relationships and accountability. They are choices about who carries the risk of a research project and who carries its benefits. Decolonial methodology, as the contributors to this volume understand it, begins from those questions rather than deferring them to an ethics committee review. It asks them before the research design is settled, during the

fieldwork, and again when it comes time to write. Furthermore, in relation to the methodologies used, and borrowing from decolonial approaches, men have been the primary sources of public knowledge about women. They formulated theories about women, made pronouncements, and advised on how women should live their lives. Research methodologies have been inadequate and inaccurate because they have ignored women's lived realities as a source of public knowledge. This book demonstrates, for example in Chapter 2, how women's lived realities can be placed at the centre of knowledge creation. Traditional and colonial methods refuse to acknowledge that all human beings have a biased and limited view of the world, biased because it begins with self, and limited because it is restricted by experience. We can therefore say that, theoretically, there are many ways of seeing the world, such that insisting on only one way invalidates others' experiences.

Few institutions recognise the shortcomings of these methodologies. Most would rather a researcher demonstrate procedural compliance than genuine relationship with the communities whose lives the research enters. What these chapters show is that the more demanding path also tends to produce more honest knowledge. That should not be surprising, but in my experience, it still needs to be said.

The Africa Research and Impact Network, under whose auspices this volume is published, occupies a position that makes this kind of work both possible and necessary. An African institution, accountable to African communities and to the integrity of African scholarship, publishing work that refuses the terms under which African knowledge has been made to seek permission.

I recommend this book to scholars, students, practitioners, and policymakers who are willing to sit with the discomfort of recognising how much the existing architecture of knowledge was built to exclude. That recognition is not the end of the work. It is where the work begins.

Prof. Wanjiku Mukabi Kabira

Professor Emeritus of Literature and African Women's Studies

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PREFACE

The title of this book is not metaphorical. Reclaiming knowledge is a precise description of what the chapters assembled here actually do. Across Africa, Latin America, and the broader Global South, ways of knowing that predate European colonial encounters have been systematically marginalised, not because they lacked rigour or coherence, but because the institutions that came to govern what counted as legitimate knowledge were built to exclude them. This volume is a response to that history, and to its continuing effects on how research is framed, conducted, and evaluated today.

I came to this project through my work at the Africa Research and Impact Network (ARIN), where the relationship between knowledge and power is not an abstraction but an institutional reality encountered daily. ARIN operates at the intersection of research, policy, and community practice across Africa, and that positioning makes certain questions unavoidable: Whose analysis shapes policy? Whose evidence is considered credible? Who defines the terms within which African realities are studied and discussed? These are not rhetorical questions. They have consequences for funding, for publication, for whose research reaches decision-makers and whose does not.

Editing this collection required sustained engagement with those questions at the level of practice. The contributors come from Kenya, Ghana, Colombia, Brazil, Mexico, Belgium, Portugal, Sweden, the Netherlands, and the United Kingdom. They work across philosophy, social work, urban planning, education, and ecology. What they share is not a common disciplinary framework but a common intellectual disposition: a refusal to treat Western epistemological conventions as the natural starting point for inquiry, and a commitment to showing, concretely, what research looks like when that refusal is carried through. My task as editor was to hold that shared disposition without flattening the real differences in how each contributor enacts it. Every chapter in this volume has its own methodological logic, its own community relationships, its own scholarly lineage. Preserving that integrity, while ensuring the collection argued coherently as a whole, was the central editorial challenge.

The methodologies assembled in these pages are not speculative. They are drawn from fieldwork conducted with Indigenous communities in northeastern Brazil, with Afro-Colombian women rebuilding collective life after displacement, with forest stewards in Veracruz, with urban residents in South Africa, India, and the United Kingdom who have experienced research as a form of extraction rather than a resource for change. Ubuntu philosophy, *vivencias*, participatory cartography, transformative learning, indigenised social work practice: each of these represents an epistemological tradition with its own internal standards of validity and its own account of what research is for. None of them require Western theoretical validation to be taken seriously. This book asks the reader to

operate from that premise.

The subtitle, *Decolonial Methodologies from the Global South*, carries a deliberate emphasis. The preposition matters. This is not a book about the Global South, written for audiences elsewhere who wish to understand it better. It is a book produced from within the intellectual and institutional life of the Global South, by scholars who are accountable to the communities their research engages. That distinction shapes everything: how the questions were formed, how the fieldwork was conducted, how the analysis was written, and what the contributors consider a sufficient standard of accountability.

A word about what this book does not claim. It does not propose a unified alternative to Western epistemology, nor does it suggest that the methodologies presented here are transferable wholesale across contexts. Decolonial research is not a method that can be imported and applied; it is a practice that must be developed in relation to specific histories, specific communities, and specific institutional conditions. What the chapters do share is an insistence that those conditions matter: that methodology is never innocent, and that researchers are responsible for the relationships their work creates or perpetuates. In that insistence, the volume stakes a clear position: rigour and accountability are not in tension. They are the same demand, made from different directions.

I am grateful to the contributors for their patience with a process that demanded more than most academic publishing requires. Several chapters were revised substantially, not to smooth them into a house style, but to ensure that the arguments were as precise and as honest as the authors intended. I am also grateful to ARIN, and in particular to Dr Joanes Atela, for maintaining the institutional commitment to publish work of this kind through ARIN Press, work that does not simplify its politics for the sake of wider circulation.

The reader will bring their own disciplinary formation to these pages, and some of what they find here will unsettle assumptions they may not have known they were making. That unsettlement is not incidental to the book's purpose. It is the purpose. Knowledge, as these chapters insist, is always produced under particular conditions and in the service of particular ends. Reclaiming it means being clear-eyed about those conditions and willing to change them.

Florence Onyango

Editor, Africa Research and Impact Network

INTRODUCTION

Research is never a neutral enterprise. Across history, it has functioned not only as a tool for discovery but also as an instrument of power, classification, and control. For much of Africa and the wider Global South, research has been entangled with colonial projects that privileged European epistemologies while devaluing or erasing Indigenous knowledge systems. The authority of "science" and "objectivity" was invoked to justify domination, producing hierarchies of knowledge that cast Europe as the centre of reason and progress while relegating colonised peoples to the margins of intellectual life. These legacies continue to shape how research is conceptualised, conducted, and applied, often in ways that perpetuate inequities.

This book emerges in response to those legacies. It argues that Africa's sustainable future depends not on replicating Western models of knowledge and development but on reclaiming and centring its own philosophical traditions. At the heart of this book lies Ubuntu, understood here not simply as a cultural expression but as a comprehensive philosophical system with ontological, epistemological, and ethical dimensions. Ubuntu presents a relational worldview that challenges Western assumptions about autonomy, competition, and hierarchy by emphasising interconnectedness, collective responsibility, and human dignity. It grounds knowledge in relationships between people, ancestors, descendants, nature, and the spiritual world, providing conceptual resources for rethinking how research is framed and how societies pursue justice and development.

The chapters in this volume move systematically from critique to reconstruction and application. They interrogate the philosophical foundations of colonialism, examine the historical construction of racial categories and Black identity, and revisit both external interpretations and internal articulations of African thought. They establish Ubuntu as a rigorous philosophical foundation, and then extend its implications into methodology, education, economics, and governance. Taken together, they form an argument for intellectual decolonisation that is at once critical and constructive: dismantling inherited hierarchies of knowledge while proposing viable alternatives rooted in African wisdom.

A central theme running through this volume is the situated nature of knowledge. Research questions, methods, and interpretations are always embedded within wider relations of power. The persistence of structural hierarchies, where the Global North is positioned as the locus of theory and the Global South as a source of raw data, demands critical interrogation. Equally important is the recognition of researcher positionality, shaped by race, gender, class, and institutional affiliation, which influences both how research is conducted and how it is received. Several chapters highlight how conventional research practices have generated fatigue, mistrust, and even harm in communities repeatedly studied without meaningful benefit, underscoring the urgent need for

transformation.

Decolonising methodologies, as the contributors show, require more than supplementing Western methods with local perspectives. They involve fundamentally rethinking what counts as knowledge and how it is generated. This includes valuing oral traditions, storytelling, testimonies, and collective forms of inquiry as valid and rigorous modes of knowledge production. It requires long-term, reciprocal relationships between researchers and communities rather than extractive encounters. It calls for reflexivity not only at the level of individual researchers but also within institutions that structure how research is funded, evaluated, and disseminated.

The chapters that follow do not claim to resolve the profound challenges of decolonising knowledge. Instead, they open space for re-examining assumptions and for testing alternative approaches. They demonstrate that decolonisation is not a singular event but an ongoing process requiring sustained attention to history, context, and power. At the same time, they provide concrete examples of how African scholars and practitioners are reshaping research so that it is accountable to communities, attentive to historical injustices, and responsive to the intellectual resources embedded in Indigenous traditions.

Ultimately, this book presents both a rigorous intellectual analysis and a practical vision. It shows that Africa possesses the philosophical and methodological resources not only to chart its own path of development but also to contribute to global conversations on sustainability, justice, and human flourishing. By centring Ubuntu as a living philosophy, the volume argues that Africa's future must be built upon its own wisdom traditions, traditions that affirm that human existence is inseparable from community, that knowledge emerges from relationships, and that dignity is realised in the flourishing of the whole.

Chapter 1

African Philosophy of Ubuntu and the Decolonising of Knowledge for Africa's Sustainable Development

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Abstract

Africa has endured centuries of colonial philosophical underpinnings that justified European expansion, the partitioning of the continent, and its ongoing neo-exploitation. The Western liberal philosophy and anthropology of the 18th and 19th centuries advanced the "4Cs" theory, Colonialism, Christianisation, Commerce, and Civilisation, to legitimise and sustain Africa's subjugation. This chapter critically examines the enduring impact of colonialism on African intellectualism and governance, arguing for the urgent need to dismantle colonial thought patterns embedded within the ruling elite and academia. Viewed through a Eurocentric lens, Africa was stripped of its identity, heritage, and autonomy, reducing its people to subjects within an imposed framework of dependency. Colonial, imperialist, and capitalist ideologies glorified foreign dominance, fostering a deep-seated reliance on former colonial powers, one that continues to inhibit Africa's ability to shape its own future. Beyond occupying physical territory, colonialism profoundly entrenched itself in the African psyche, stifling Indigenous knowledge production and the continent's path toward sustainable development. This intellectual and epistemological crisis spans crucial sectors, including education, governance, religion, spirituality, health, economy, and development. As a result, Africa struggles to leverage its own abundant natural and intellectual resources to achieve sustainable growth. This chapter argues that reclaiming Africa's Indigenous epistemological frameworks, particularly Ubuntu Philosophy, can restore confidence in African intellectual traditions and empower the continent to build a future grounded in its rich precolonial knowledge systems. It advocates for the decolonisation of thought and scholarship by highlighting practical applications of Ubuntu Philosophy in sub-Saharan Africa. Through diverse methodologies, narratives, and perspectives, this work contributes to the ongoing discourse on sustainability and the decolonisation of knowledge.

Keywords: sustainability · Ubuntu Philosophy · decolonisation · epistemological crisis

Introduction

The debate surrounding Ubuntu Philosophy and the decolonisation of knowledge is deeply rooted in postcolonial discourse. Ashcroft et al. (2007) define decolonisation as *"the process of revealing and dismantling colonialist power in all its forms."* This includes eliminating the underlying institutional and cultural structures that sustained colonial dominance, many of which persist even after political independence. Sheila Nair (2017) further argues that the prefix "post" in postcolonial studies underscores how colonial and imperial histories continue to shape global perspectives, marginalising non-Western knowledge systems.

Postcolonial literature emphasises that independence did not equate to full liberation from colonial values. Political, economic, and cultural structures inherited from colonial regimes remained intact, shaping governance, scholarship and development policies (Ashcroft et al., 2007). Initially, the term *postcolonial* was used in literary circles to explore cultural interactions within colonial societies (Ashcroft et al., 2007). However, later critics shifted the focus to the material consequences of colonialism, highlighting its lingering effects on contemporary African societies (Ashcroft et al., 2007). Key scholars in postcolonial thought, including Edward Said (1978), Ngugi wa Thiong'o (1981, 1986, 1993), Homi Bhabha (1984), Gayatri Spivak (1996), and Robert Young (2003), have contributed significantly to this discourse. In Africa, the works of Frantz Fanon, Achilles Mbembe, Claude Ake, and Ngugi wa Thiong'o have been particularly influential in shaping debates on decolonisation in knowledge production, science, technology, and innovation. Recent scholarship grounded in Ubuntu has emerged, particularly in South Africa, fostering critical reflections on social transformation

Kwasi Wiredu (1998) warns that colonialism caused an involuntary intermingling of Western and African intellectual traditions, distorting African thought. He advocates for conceptual decolonisation, urging contemporary African scholars to disentangle foreign epistemologies from Indigenous perspectives. Similarly, Ngugi wa Thiong'o's (1986) concept of "decolonising the mind" is central to addressing Africa's epistemic crisis. Education in Africa suffers from a lack of authentic African epistemic models, forcing scholars to rely on borrowed frameworks rather than Indigenous methodologies.

Brown (1993) defines epistemology as *"the branch of philosophy that examines the nature, grounds, and validity of knowledge."* It asks fundamental questions: What constitutes knowledge? How is knowledge acquired? How can it be justified? How reliable is our understanding of reality? Epistemological assumptions shape research methodologies, data collection techniques, and analytical frameworks, influencing knowledge production in Africa. Research approaches: positivist, constructivist, critical realist, and interpretivist, vary in their methodologies for investigating knowledge. The challenge lies in fostering endogenous knowledge production, privileging African perspectives over externally imposed epistemologies.

To achieve sustainable development, Africa must shift from exogenous to endogenous knowledge systems, from externally imposed intellectual traditions to Indigenous African frameworks. Endogenous knowledge, produced from within, harnesses local contexts, values, and traditions rather than relying on Western epistemic models. The concept of *decolonising the mind* challenges the epistemic legacies of colonialism, dismantling Eurocentric hierarchies of knowledge.

Casper Andersen (2018) highlights the epistemic coloniality embedded in Western thought, where non-Western knowledge systems are marginalised. He argues that dominant Western epistemologies tend to prioritise objectivity, detaching the knower from the known, an approach inconsistent with African epistemologies. Nkafu (1999), drawing from Vincent Mulago and Alexis Kagame, conceptualises African vitology as a holistic philosophical approach, rooted in life experience and interconnectedness.

The bottom-up approach to knowledge production, as explored in studies by Rits et al. (2011), reinforces the importance of Indigenous methodologies in shaping sustainable development in Africa. While the contexts differ, these findings can be adapted to African realities. This chapter argues for reclaiming African knowledge systems as vital instruments for Africa's sustainable development, embedded in the philosophy of Ubuntu.

This chapter embraces a unified African identity, acknowledging that colonial narratives fragment Africa into multiple conceptual entities. Inspired by Pan-Africanism, it aligns with the ideals of Edward Wilmot Blyden, a foundational figure in anti-colonial thought whose works influenced the Negritude and Black Consciousness movements. Ubuntu, now recognised as a defining philosophical framework for Africa, provides a cohesive epistemic foundation that counters Western-centric narratives.

The first section of this chapter examines the colonial legacy, focusing on Western misrepresentations of Africa. Mudimbe (1994) argues that defining Africa necessitates confronting historical distortions, where Western disciplines such as anthropology, history, and theology subsumed African realities under external constructs.

The second section explores Africa's intellectual emancipation, tracing the emergence of Black identity and resistance against 18th- and 19th-century liberal philosophies and anthropologies. Central figures such as Edward Wilmot Blyden shaped 20th-century African political thought.

The final section examines the development of Bantu Philosophy, particularly Placide Tempels' (1945) framework, and the evolution of Ubuntu Philosophy as an endogenous African epistemological method for interrogating reality.

The Colonial Legacy and the Production of Knowledge

The 18th and 19th centuries marked the emergence of modern anthropology, the scientific study of human cultures. This period coincided with the Enlightenment, a European intellectual movement that profoundly influenced global political thought, international economic policy, and the cultural hegemony of the West. The French philosopher D'Alembert referred to the 18th century as "*the century of philosophy par excellence*." Influenced by the Scientific Revolution of the 16th and 17th centuries, Enlightenment thinkers such as Thomas Hobbes, Immanuel Kant, John Locke, David Hume, and René Descartes laid the foundations for modern Western epistemology. Their methodologies became dominant, almost exclusively so, marginalising other forms of knowledge as inferior or unscientific.

Within this intellectual climate, Europe established itself as the universal standard of knowledge. Alternative epistemologies, such as African philosophy, were dismissed as metaphorical or non-philosophical (Ladrière, 1979). As European colonial powers expanded during the mid-19th century, they sought philosophical and theoretical justifications for the subjugation of entire populations based on racial hierarchies. This epistemic violence dismantled Africa's rich intellectual heritage and justified the social injustices that followed, including slavery, racism, and exploitation.

Scholars from diverse disciplines, anthropology, philosophy, economics, and natural sciences, played instrumental roles in legitimising colonialism. The expansionist ideology was built upon four pillars, often referred to as the "4 Cs": Colonisation, Christianisation, Commerce, and Civilisation. These ideas were propagated by early explorers, missionaries, and colonial administrators, and continue to reverberate even in the 21st century.

Anthropological societies emerged as think tanks for racial theory. The Anthropological Society of Paris (founded in 1859), the Anthropological Society of London (established in 1863 after splitting from the Ethnological Society of London, which was founded in 1843), and the Berlin Anthropological Society (established in 1869) were key institutions that contributed to the development of racial science. Central to their internal debates was the "Negro question" and the opposing theories of monogenism (common human origin) and polygenism (distinct racial origins). These societies developed and promoted physical anthropology as a justification for classifying human beings along racial lines. Race became a pseudo-scientific tool for legitimising social hierarchies. Non-Europeans were objectified and studied through a Eurocentric lens, constructed as intellectually and morally inferior beings, and therefore deserving of colonisation.

Philosophers and scientists of the Enlightenment and post-Enlightenment eras, including David Hume (1711–1776), George-Louis Leclerc, Comte de Buffon (1707–1788), Charles Darwin (1809–1882), Alfred Russel Wallace (1823–1913), Adam Smith (1723–1790) and John Stuart Mill (1806–1873), provided the epistemological scaffolding for colonial ideologies. Adam Smith's seminal work, *An Inquiry into the Nature and Causes of the*

Wealth of Nations (1776), became a foundational text for liberal economic theory, used to justify colonial economic expansion.

Colonial powers such as England and France assumed the self-appointed role of "civilising" African peoples, whom they deemed backward and uncultured. This worldview was underpinned by social Darwinism, a perversion of Darwin's theory of evolution, which suggested that it was the humanitarian duty of Europeans to bring a "superior" civilisation to the "dark continent." Darwin's own writings, along with those of his contemporaries, reinforced racial hierarchies by equating the intellectual capacities of Africans with those of animals.

One of the most egregious examples of this ideology can be found in David Hume's essay "*Of National Characters*", in which he wrote:

"I am apt to suspect the negroes to be naturally inferior to the whites. There never was a civilised nation of any other complexion than white, nor even any individual eminent either in action or speculation. No ingenious manufactures amongst them, no arts, no sciences...Such a uniform and constant difference could not happen in so many countries and ages if nature had not made an original distinction between these breeds of men. Not to mention our colonies, there are Negro slaves dispersed all over Europe, of which none ever discovered any symptoms of ingenuity; tho' low (white) people, without education, will start up amongst us, and distinguish themselves in every profession" (See Duodu, 2011).

This statement typifies the racist and colonial mentality of the Enlightenment era, which profoundly influenced 19th-century anthropology. James Hunt (1863), founder of the Anthropological Society of London, claimed that "Negroes were mentally inferior to Europeans and should be classified as a distinct species." His colleague, Richard Burton (1864), asserted that Africans lacked the intellectual potential attributed to them by philanthropists. Inspired by Darwinist thought, they argued that the intellectual development of Africans was comparable to that of animals (Martin Guy, 2011).

During the same period, Arthur de Gobineau developed racial and racist theories that influenced the French assimilation policy. Gobineau is best known for his *Essay on the Inequality of the Human Races*, written in 1854. His work was so influential that he is considered the father of modern racism (Fluehr-Lobban, 2000).

The impact of such theories on Africa is well articulated by Robert Young:

"Colonial and imperial rule was legitimised by anthropological theories which portrayed the peoples of the colonised world as inferior, childlike, or feminine, incapable of looking after themselves and requiring the paternal rule of the West for their own best interests (today they are deemed to require 'development'). The basis of such anthropological theories was the concept of race. In simple terms, the West-non-West relationship was thought of in terms of whites versus the non-white races" (Young, 2003).

Despite these misrepresentations, Africa had a rich history, culture, governance systems, economies and international relations well before the colonial era. Thriving relations existed between Africa and the Asian continent long before European intervention.

Within the mercantilist ideology of the time, "evolution, conquest, and difference became signs of a theological, biological, and anthropological destiny" (Mudimbe, 1988). As Mudimbe explains, "it is during this period that both imperialism and anthropology took place, allowing the reification of the primitive." This Western-imposed negative representation of Africa would go on to have far-reaching consequences on African socio-political and economic systems, as well as on African self-perception.

This damaging image of black identity, as constructed by Europeans, is powerfully critiqued by Frantz Fanon in his seminal work *Peau Noire, Masques Blancs* (1952), later translated into English as *Black Skin, White Masks*. According to Fanon, "white culture had created a false image of black people, which made it difficult to grasp the true nature of black identity." His book is a profound critique of race theory and has had a lasting impact on Black consciousness and identity politics.

Towards Reclaiming Africa's Traditional Body of Knowledge

Marcus Garvey once wrote, "*A people without knowledge of their history, origin and culture is like a tree without roots.*" The discourse on coloniality and decoloniality must necessarily consider the epistemological frameworks through which the West understood and misrepresented Africa. As such, it becomes essential to situate the debate around Ubuntu philosophy within this broader historical context.

Africa's quest to reclaim its endogenous knowledge systems as a means of shaping its own future stands as a powerful counter-narrative to colonial discourse. In this regard, Onyebuchi Eze (2011) argues that Ubuntu philosophy is "best understood as a critique of the logic of colonialism."

However, in Eze's analysis, particularly within the South African context, Ubuntu has been interpreted in multiple ways. The first perspective views Ubuntu as "*merely an anachronistic philosophy produced by African academics.*" The second considers it "*an ideology appropriated for political ends.*" The third interpretation is rooted in the historical context within which Ubuntu developed as a philosophical concept.

Despite such critiques, Ubuntu remains a valid and widely discussed epistemological framework. A wealth of literature, authored by both African and non-African scholars, employs Ubuntu as an original and relevant theoretical foundation within the social sciences.

Just as a historical review of the colonial discourse is essential, so too is a critical exploration of the journey toward rediscovering Africa's authentic body of knowledge. Reclaiming these knowledge systems is not only an act of intellectual decolonisation but also a crucial step in reimagining Africa's future on its own terms.

Black Identity and Africa's Emancipation

As early as the mid-19th century, voices from Africa and the Caribbean began to challenge the negative portrayals of Africa and the objectification of African people. These thinkers were critical of a worldview that positioned the West in opposition to the so-called "Other." One of the key African intellectuals of this period was Edward Wilmot Blyden.

Blyden defended the distinctiveness of African identity in response to Western misrepresentations of African regeneration, which, according to Mudimbe, "consistently involved reduction of differences into a Western historicity" (Mudimbe, 1988). Any meaningful study of Blyden must consider this historical backdrop, which profoundly shaped his political thought and that of many contemporaries who resisted the imposition of Western identity.

As Viera Pawlikova-Vilhanova observes, this era marked:

"a period in African history when, regardless of their own wishes, Africans were bound to be drawn out of their way of life and brought into a new relationship with the outside world and under the impact of an expanding Western civilisation which was in the process of moulding the world in its image. It was during this period that first West Africans in Sierra Leone, Senegal, and Liberia, and later Africans in other parts of the continent, were confronted with the presence of Europe and forced to deal with the intrusion of Western ideas, moral and ethical codes, including Western religion (Christianity), as well as Western political institutions and economic patterns" (Pawlikova, 1998, p. 162).

In this context, Blyden developed the concept of the "African Personality" as a direct response to the racist ideologies of the London and Paris schools of anthropology. Contrary to these dehumanising theories, he emphasised the uniqueness and dignity of African identity. Blyden asserted, "The African is an African, and the European is a European, and will remain so forever." His principle of respecting the "Other as Other" stood in stark contrast to French assimilationist policies, which sought to erase African identity in favour of European norms.

Blyden championed the preservation of African identity and culture, warning against the destruction of Indigenous institutions. He wrote, "*That every race, it is now being recognised, has a soul, and the soul of the race finds expression in its institutions. To kill those institutions is to kill the soul—a terrible homicide*" (Blyden, 1905).

He advocated for safeguarding Africa's heritage by highlighting the intrinsic differences between African and European cultures. He spoke of "African spirituality," rooted in communal values and cooperative systems, in contrast to the individualism and egoism he associated with Western societies. Communal property and collective effort, he argued, were central features of African social organisation. Blyden first used the term "African Personality" around 1883 to call for the recognition of Africa's distinct identity, an identity that deserved to be respected and celebrated.

According to Guy Martin, Blyden's thought significantly influenced many 20th-century intellectuals and leaders, including Marcus Garvey, George Padmore and Kwame Nkrumah (Martin, 2012, p. 48). Nkrumah would later develop the concept of African Personality as part of his own political and philosophical vision for post-independence Africa.

Blyden's philosophy also laid the groundwork for movements such as Negritude and Black Consciousness. Championed by Aimé Césaire, Léon-Gontran Damas, and Léopold Sédar Senghor, the Negritude Movement was a cultural, philosophical and political revolt against racism and French colonial domination. For Senghor, Negritude represented "*the sum total of the values of Black world civilisation.*" Césaire defined it as "*a simple recognition of the fact of being Black, and the acceptance of this fact, of our destiny as Blacks, of our history, and of our culture*" (Thompson, 2002).

According to Thompson, "Blackness or Africanness was made to justify everything about Negritude, not only its *raison d'être* but all the themes of its opposition to the West" (Thompson, 2002). The concept of Negritude is closely aligned with the African philosophy of *ubuntu* and is intricately linked to the notion of African Personality. This understanding is well articulated by scholars such as John Samuel Mbiti and Desmond Tutu. Mbiti's now-classic expression, "*I am because we are*", captures the communal nature of African identity. Similarly, Desmond Tutu stated:

"A person is a person through other persons. None of us comes into the world fully formed. We would not know how to think, or walk, or speak, or behave as human beings unless we learned it from other human beings. We need other human beings to be human" (Tutu, 2004).

For Senghor, the strengthening of distinct African cultural values was essential for the authentic development of the African Personality. He viewed Negritude as a "certain way of being human and, above all, of living as human." In his later years, Senghor increasingly adopted the concept of *Africanity* in place of Negritude to encompass the broader Afro-Arab cultural spectrum. Much of this philosophical orientation draws directly from Blyden's foundational ideas on African Personality. In this regard, Blyden may rightly be considered a precursor to the Negritude Movement and a powerful voice in the affirmation of Black identity in opposition to white supremacist ideologies.

A study by Chris Dunton (2003) demonstrates how both the Black Consciousness Movement and the idea of Africa's renaissance find their intellectual roots in Blyden's

work. Blyden's philosophy significantly influenced the development of Black Consciousness, both in the United States during the civil rights era, through figures like Malcolm X and Martin Luther King Jr. and in South Africa with the emergence of the Black Consciousness Movement. His early advocacy for Black dignity and identity laid the foundation for these later struggles against racism, segregation, colonialism, and apartheid. Blyden vehemently opposed theories of white superiority and was a pioneer in promoting a counter-narrative centred on Black consciousness.

Inspired by these same ideas, Stephen Bantu Biko (1946–1977) and the Black Consciousness Movement in South Africa rejected the institutionalised racism imposed by the apartheid regime. However, the intellectual genealogy of South African Black Consciousness can be traced even earlier, to Pixley ka Isaka Seme, who in 1906 delivered a landmark speech titled "*The Regeneration of Africa*." Seme would later become president of the African National Congress, though he remains largely unrecognised in contemporary South African memory.

Among other notable critics of the Western and Eurocentric view of Africa are Frantz Fanon (1952) with *Black Skin, White Masks*; Nigerian novelist Chinua Achebe (1958); Ugandan poet and philosopher Okot p'Bitek (1966); Congolese philosopher Vumbi Yoka Mudimbe (1988, 1994); and Kenyan writer Ngugi wa Thiong'o (1981, 1986). These thinkers critically examined the role of language as a colonial instrument, used by colonisers to dominate not only land and resources but also the minds and identities of the colonised.

As Drabinski (2019) explains in the *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*:

"To speak a language is to participate in a world, to adopt a civilisation. The claim reflects in many ways the philosophical milieu of mid-century French and German philosophy, which in phenomenology, existentialism, and hermeneutics, explores the very same claim, that language, subjectivity and reality are entangled as a matter of essence, not confusion or indistinction. However, the colonial situation renders this relationship more complex. If speaking a language means participating in a world and adopting a civilisation, then the language of the colonised, imposed through centuries of colonial domination and dedicated to the erasure or abjection of other expressive forms, articulates the world of the coloniser. To speak as the colonised, therefore, is to participate in one's own oppression and to reproduce the very structures of alienation in everything from vocabulary to syntax and intonation" (Drabinski, 2019).

V.Y. Mudimbe further elucidates the colonial project. According to him, the writings of 19th-century explorers and travellers: "represent a body of knowledge constructed with the explicit purpose of faithfully translating and deciphering the African object. Indeed, it fulfilled a political project in which, supposedly, the object unveils its being, its secrets, and its potential to a master who could finally domesticate it" (Mudimbe, 1994).

No reflection on the Western and Eurocentric view of the world would be complete without mentioning Jack Goody's influential work *The Theft of History* (2006). Goody's

book critically examines how the West has historically portrayed the "Other," dissecting no fewer than fifteen foundational myths used to justify Western dominance. His work is particularly noteworthy as a self-reflective critique emerging from within the Western academic tradition.

The Emergence of Bantu Philosophy

This chapter section does not seek to resolve the question of whether African philosophy exists, a subject that has already been extensively debated in the works of Placide Tempels (1959), John Mbiti (1969), Kwame Gyekye (1987), V.Y. Mudimbe (1988), and Paulin Hountondji (1995), among others. A similar debate emerged in theological circles, most notably between Alfred Vanneste, a professor of dogmatic theology at Lovanium University in Kinshasa, and his student Tharcisse Tshibangu. While Tshibangu advocated for a theology with an African orientation, Vanneste defended a more universalist approach. According to Vanneste, "African theologians have nothing to gain in doubling up over their own selves. They would condemn themselves inevitably to remain second-rate theologians" (Bénézet and Muya, 2003).

This tension mirrors the broader philosophical and epistemological approach to knowledge production in Africa, often viewed through a dialectic between a universalist position, typically equated with Westernisation and a particularist position representing the "Other," as defined by the West.

Horton (1976) and Hountondji (1977) define African philosophy as the work of Africans engaged in academic philosophical practice. In contrast, Mudimbe (1988) introduces the notion of African gnosis. He raises two key concerns: first, the form, content, and style of "Africanising" knowledge; and second, the status of traditional systems of thought and their relationship to normative knowledge. His central question is: *To what extent can one speak of African knowledge, and in what sense?* He argues that both Western interpreters and African scholars often rely on conceptual frameworks rooted in a Western epistemological order, resulting in a "silent dependence on a Western episteme." From this standpoint, both knowledge and philosophical thought in Africa demand urgent decolonisation, so they may become a shared, universal property of humanity.

Placide Tempels, a Belgian Franciscan who worked in what is now the Democratic Republic of Congo, is widely regarded as the pioneer of Bantu philosophy. He was one of the first non-African advocates for a coherent African philosophical system and stood apart from his missionary contemporaries, many of whom still considered Africans as "primitive" or "savage." In his groundbreaking work, *Bantu Philosophy*, Tempels challenged Western assumptions about African worldviews and the legitimacy of African knowledge systems embedded in customs and traditions.

Up until the mid-1950s, many Western scholars and missionaries continued to portray African traditions as animism, fetishism, ancestor worship, magic, and other pejorative terms. Tempels, however, argued that Bantu customs are grounded in a single philosophical principle: the Inmost Nature of Being, or their ontological principle. Vincent Mulago (1955) described this as "*Force Vitale*", a vital force that animates all beings. Drawing inspiration from this concept, Nkafu Nkemnkia (1999) developed the idea of African Vitology, which he defines as "a thought system that defines itself with life, experienced in a unified vision of all that can be known."

Influenced by developments in anthropology and sociology during the 1960s, Pope Paul VI would later affirm in 1967 that Africa's body of thought constitutes a valid system of knowledge, contrary to earlier dismissals by missionaries and anthropologists.

Nevertheless, criticism of Tempels' approach has emerged over time. In an article on *Bantu Philosophy*, Okot p'Bitek (1975) wrote:

"Fr. Tempels carried out his research only among the Bemba of Lake Mweru and the Baluba. Out of this, he erected a thought-system which he confidently labelled 'Bantu'. And although he did not test this against the beliefs of the Zulus, Ganda, Nyoro, and numerous other Bantu peoples, Fr. Tempels invites us to accept this system not only as Bantu but as African."

Decolonisation of Education and Knowledge

Contemporary educational philosophy is heavily influenced by the global geopolitical order, often at the expense of context-specific African worldviews and knowledge systems. The legacy of colonial education, delivered without regard for African cultures, beliefs, or practices, continues to manifest in subtle yet profound ways, shaping everything from curriculum to institutional structures.

The historical denial of African knowledge systems has left African nations reliant on their former colonial powers for models of human development. While Africans have adopted Western education, political systems, and cultural frameworks, many countries still struggle to attain sustainable development, technological advancement, political stability, and food and water security. Development partners and international agencies have played a role in embedding Western ideals into African educational curricula, furthering a form of neocolonialism through education.

The purpose of this chapter is to advocate for a fundamental reorientation of ontological, epistemological, and methodological approaches to decolonise knowledge production. This shift will create new opportunities to highlight the significance of Africa-centred knowledge, as envisioned by Dr Kwame Nkrumah.

According to Mudimbe (1988), colonial powers systematically transformed non-European societies into European constructs. He analyses what he calls the *colonising structure* through three complementary hypotheses. The first concerns the domination of physical space, referring to the acquisition, distribution, and exploitation of land in colonies. The second examines the reformation of Indigenous minds, which includes policies designed to domesticate and control the native populations. The third explores how local economic histories were assimilated into Western frameworks, reshaping ancient organisations and imposing new modes of production.

The policies enacted under colonial rule led to the systematic underdevelopment of Africa, creating a *body of knowledge* geared toward exploiting dependencies. Walter Rodney's seminal work, *How Europe Underdeveloped Africa* (1972, revised in 1981), provides a comprehensive analysis of these factors, illustrating how political leadership, economic control, and security apparatuses were used to maintain dominance. His insights remain relevant today.

Thus, any serious discourse on Africa's sustainable development must begin with the decolonisation of the structures that have historically hindered the continent's ability to advance.

Decolonisation aligns with the ambitions of Agenda 2063, the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) and African development priorities underpinned by the philosophy of *Ubuntu*. Universities and other higher education institutions are vital in this transformation. They must lead efforts to reassert African-centred knowledge that is empowering, relevant, and reflective of local realities.

Within this educational context, decolonisation means more than symbolic change; it requires confronting the colonising values and perspectives still embedded in African curricula. Much of the post-colonial history taught across Africa prioritises Western narratives, distorting African identities, cultures, and epistemologies. As Battiste (2013) explains, Indigenous students have endured a system of forced assimilation, in which their heritage and knowledge are rejected and ignored.

Colonial education systems were designed to produce elites who would serve colonial interests, whereas authentic African education seeks to uplift society and serve humanity. This historical legacy has entrenched a pernicious ideology of white superiority, which many Africans have internalized, leading them to perceive themselves as relegated to a subordinate position within the global hierarchy of humanity.

Kenya's recent shift from the 8-4-4 system to the Competency-Based Curriculum (3-6-6-3) is a step toward educational decolonisation. Such reforms must prioritise Indigenous knowledge systems, place-based learning, and epistemologies that reflect African realities. According to the Centre for Youth and Society in Canada, "part of the process of decolonising education is re-establishing links to the community." Education must be contextual, participatory, and community-anchored to empower learners and

restore the integrity of African ways of knowing.

The objective of education is to enable individuals to know their Creator, understand how to relate with Him, and become empowered with the knowledge needed to lead honourable and purposeful lives. With sound education, one should be mentally, physically, and socially equipped to live a healthy and meaningful life. Acquiring knowledge should not be an end in itself, but rather a means to stimulate elevated moral and spiritual consciousness, leading to faith, ethical behaviour, and righteous action.

It is crucial to recognise that anthropological, engineering, environmental, water, mineral, atmospheric, biodiversity, and oceanic studies are all part of the intricate design of the Creator. God has not drawn boundaries in knowledge; rather, He has viewed humanity as one unified creation, deserving of universal access to and value from knowledge. When this universality is absent in the knowledge landscape, it becomes necessary to ask more radical questions about the prevailing epistemological approaches found in literature.

Creating a well-informed foundation for decolonising knowledge requires taking a critical step back to examine and disrupt dominant norms that shape how knowledge is produced, particularly regarding our worldview and our place within it. As Gordon Crawford et al. (2021) assert in the *Journal of the British Academy* article titled "Decolonising knowledge production on Africa: why it's still necessary and what can be done," reimagining knowledge production is a necessary step toward intellectual liberation and justice.

To develop education with a community orientation, we must reflect deeply on the goals of education. Such reflection can reveal the motives, strategies, drivers, and visions embedded in colonial educational policies. Perhaps the most critical element of decolonisation lies in the ongoing interrogation of curriculum content, power dynamics, learning structures, education policies, and institutional objectives.

Decolonising education and knowledge fundamentally involves rethinking the structures of educational institutions and their broader roles in society. As Asher (2009) notes, "The work of decolonisation entails not only our self-reflexive efforts to work through mind-numbing alienation and essentialising divides, but also the commitment to transformation in social and educational contexts."

Higher education institutions in Africa are uniquely positioned to foster decolonisation. These institutions enjoy scholarly freedom and platforms that allow for critical thought and innovation. Within these spaces, African scholars and educationists can challenge dominant educational paradigms by promoting a more collective, inclusive approach to learning rather than adhering to rigid, standardised models. They can implement principles such as healing, empowerment, reflection, and place-based engagement to connect education with community realities. By validating learners' lived experiences and supporting the formation of authentic identities, education can become a

transformative and empowering process. It should value cultural heritage and local knowledge systems, promote resilience and innovation, and shift away from deficit-based perspectives. Ultimately, education must aim to nurture the whole person, intellectually, emotionally, spiritually, and culturally.

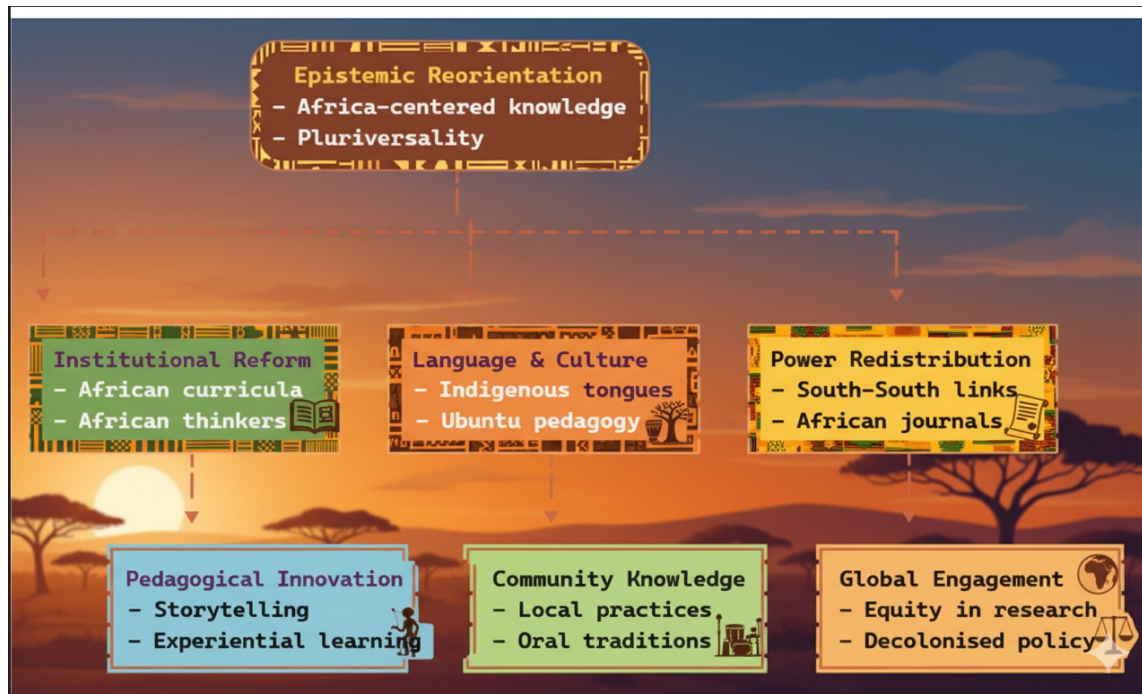


Figure 1: Africa Knowledge Decolonisation Model

The African endogenous knowledge system, which aims to decolonise knowledge production, is firmly anchored in an epistemological approach that deepens understanding and drives a paradigm shift towards a new intellectual orientation. Within this paradigm, Eurocentric dominance is significantly reduced, if not entirely dismantled. To realise the intellectual success of this decolonial vision and its methodologies, the system must be built upon several fundamental pillars. These include comprehensive institutional reform championed by forward-thinking scholars and researchers; precise, well-structured linguistic and cultural leveraging that ensures local values and traditions are recognised and appreciated by both learners and administrators; and the robust strengthening of academic scholarship, publishing networks, and collaborative partnerships. Together, these pillars and frameworks facilitate the seamless transition of theory into practical outcomes through pedagogical innovation, community-based knowledge production, and inclusive, equitable global engagement. When these interconnected factors function harmoniously within this new African educational paradigm, the dismantling of colonial legacies becomes entirely achievable, positioning Africa as a global leader and autonomous producer of its own knowledge.

Conclusion

This chapter has explored the African philosophy of *Ubuntu* and the imperative of decolonising knowledge as a foundation for Africa's sustainable development. More than 60 years after attaining political independence, Africa continues to lag behind global powers and remains heavily dependent on external forces, not only from the West but increasingly from Eastern countries such as China and India. The continent suffers under an exogenous model of development that serves foreign interests more than it meets Africa's own needs.

Alarming, many African students, academics, and politicians still question the authenticity and relevance of African thought systems in addressing the continent's challenges. Rather than drawing from Indigenous philosophies and locally grounded models, they continue to seek Western frameworks to solve African problems, approaches that fail to resonate with local realities. This mindset is a consequence of an education system shaped by Western paradigms. Many African intellectuals, trained in Western institutions, have not only adopted but internalised the negative portrayals of Africa found in Eurocentric scholarship. Frantz Fanon's classic work *Black Skin, White Masks*, vividly illustrates this psychological and intellectual colonisation.

This dilemma extends to African religion, culture, theology, and other domains of knowledge. Africa does not lack great intellectual minds, but these minds have been conditioned to position themselves within the dialectics of the West versus the "Other." This worldview, rooted in Eurocentrism, routinely denies Africa its history, culture, spirituality and intellectual traditions. The ongoing failure to decolonise knowledge production continues to impede a comprehensive understanding of African societies and their rich epistemologies.

The calls by thinkers like Ngugi wa Thiong'o, who advocates for the decolonisation of the African mind, and V.Y. Mudimbe, who interrogates the status of traditional systems of knowledge, remain urgent. Mudimbe emphasises the need to reconsider how Indigenous knowledge relates to dominant, normative systems. Similarly, Claude Ake advocates for the decolonisation of the social sciences. These arguments are echoed in the works of Gordon Crawford, Zainab Mai-Bornu, and Karl Landström, who emphasise the necessity of dismantling "false universalism" masked as Westernised canons.

South Africa presents some promising models of decolonisation that the rest of the continent can draw valuable lessons from. More broadly, however, Africa must assert both linguistic and epistemological sovereignty. If European and Asian countries educate their populations in their mother tongues, there is no reason African countries should not do the same. Language is not merely a medium of communication; it is a powerful instrument of liberation and self-determination.

Furthermore, African political leadership must cultivate intellectual independence, making decisions that prioritise the decolonisation of policies, democracy, human rights, and development itself. Higher education institutions across the continent must lead this movement by advancing science and scholarship that challenge colonial anthropological frameworks and reassert Africa's rightful place in the global knowledge ecosystem.

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Chapter 2

Vivencias, A Method Born from the Struggle for Emancipation: (Re)Valuing Other Ways of Knowing in Abya-Yala

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Abstract

Although decolonising research methodologies have opened new horizons toward a more pluriversal world, knowledge production remains the domain of a privileged minority. This contribution aims to highlight the potential of vivencias (lived experiences) to decenter and deprivilege traditional knowledge generation. To this end, the chapter describes three different transdisciplinary collaborations led by Afro-descendant women affected by the armed conflict in Colombia. Despite fear, these women refused to remain silent, using art and artistic expression as vehicles to (re)signify and (re)construct collective memory as a way to confront violence. These narratives illustrate how vivencias transformed into arts serve as a tool for (i) generating collective situated knowledge; (ii) developing critical awareness to foster social change through collective resistance; (iii) (re)valuing other ways of knowing, acting and being; and (iv) (re)inventing research practices born from the struggles in the territories.

Keywords: Decolonising · pluriversal · vivencias · knowledge · art · Afro-descendant · Colombia

Introduction

In recent years, anti-colonial and decolonial movements have gained momentum across the globe. These movements seek to transform a dehumanised, colonial, racist, and patriarchal world into one that is more pluralistic. They aim to expose and challenge the colonial heritage embedded within academic institutions (Ziai et al., 2020) by decolonising research methodologies (Chilisa, 2012; Kovach, 2009; Smith, 2012; Zavala, 2016) and interrogating the role of the researcher (Datta, 2018).

Scholars and activists alike are speaking out against the dehumanisation of –the Other– (Fals-Borda, 1995; Freire, 1970; Smith, 2012), a process that has long denied the validity of alternative knowledge systems (Maldonado-Torres, 2007, 2016; Motta, 2021). They seek to revalue and reposition historically marginalised Indigenous and local knowledge systems (Chilisa, 2017; Viquez-Fernández and Ahenakew, 2020; Wilson, 2008), along with the communities that uphold them. These movements demand both social and epistemic justice (Santos, 2014) and call for an end to the cognitive empire that currently governs knowledge production (Santos, 2018).

While some scholars advocate for adopting Indigenous methodologies to counter epistemic injustice, this approach carries risks. There is a danger of fragmenting and co-opting Indigenous and Local Knowledge (ILK) into dominant paradigms (Muller, 2012), or of "instrumentalising and embracing Indigenous research methodologies as quick-fix solutions to, or escapes from, deep-rooted and ongoing (neo)colonial thinking" (Ahenakew, 2016, p. 323).

Although efforts to decolonise knowledge production through alternative methodologies offer opportunities to bridge knowledge systems, they often fail to question who truly has the "right to research" (Appadurai, 2006). As a result, knowledge production remains largely confined to a privileged minority, defined by notions of neutrality and expertise. These privileges are grounded in the cognitive supremacy of Western epistemologies, which render other knowledge forms invisible or illegitimate (Santos, 2014).

Santos uses the metaphor of *abyssal thinking* to describe the epistemological dominance of modern Western thought. This form of thinking draws an invisible line that divides social reality, erasing what lies on the other side. In doing so, it bestows universal legitimacy on modern science, to the detriment of alternative ways of knowing, being, and relating (Rhee and Subedi, 2014).

Ziai and colleagues (2020) argue that decolonising knowledge production requires dismantling existing methodologies that perpetuate the colonality of knowledge. Meanwhile, Arturo Escobar (2016) calls for the (re)invention of research practices that do not silence local knowledge. He contends that knowledge born from the struggles to defend relational ways of life is more suitable than that produced from the detached perspective of academia. Escobar advocates for replacing dominant social theories with relational ontologies grounded in territory-based struggles that intertwine cultural, spiritual, and ecological dimensions.

Decolonising knowledge production, therefore, compels us to (re)think our privileged roles as researchers and embrace our responsibility to transform monocultural thinking into a pluriverse of knowledges (Santos, 2014). This involves decentring power and re(connecting) with the knowledge, voices, and ways of being of marginalised communities. It also calls for the inclusion of ethical (axiological), spiritual, and relational elements alongside epistemological and methodological considerations.

Similarly, decolonising collaborative research begins with questioning whose voices are amplified and whose are silenced within research processes (Chilisa, 2017). This demands that we (re)consider our historical responsibility in the production of knowledge (Rhee and Subedi, 2014). Important questions arise: Is knowledge the ultimate goal? Or is the goal to transform power relations and improve lived realities? Are we prepared to share or even relinquish control of the research process to communities? (Moreno-Cely et al., 2021). How are we disseminating our research? Are we privileging the written word?

(Santos, 2018). Such reflections must guide us before, during, and after the research process, especially since transdisciplinary collaborations risk reinforcing structures of inequality and domination, whether consciously or not (Merçon, 2021).

Although the literature provides many examples of transdisciplinary collaborations, most are initiated and led by academics who invite communities to participate in pre-defined research agendas. Far fewer examples exist of transdisciplinary research initiated and led by communities themselves. This chapter seeks to address that gap. It draws from a transformative encounter with Virgelina Chará, an Afro-Colombian woman nominated for the Nobel Peace Prize for her work with victims of Colombia's armed conflict. It is also grounded in my own experiences as a Colombian activist and Third World scholar of colour working within a European university. These reflections are a call to engage with other ways of knowing and to resist what Visvanathan (2009) describes as the "onto-epistemological apartheid." Rather than offering a universal blueprint, this chapter aims to show that it is possible to build bridges across the abyssal divide. But doing so requires us to reinvent our research practices, to incorporate epistemological, ontological, axiological, spiritual, and relational dimensions into our work.

The following three stories illustrate possibilities for (re)imagining research practices through transdisciplinary collaboration that decentralises and diversifies knowledge production. The protagonists are Afro-Colombian women who transitioned from victims of armed conflict to community leaders. Their stories emerge from their *vivencias*, deeply lived experiences, through which they used art, spirituality and solidarity to recover collective memory, pursue social justice, and revitalise ancestral and local knowledge. While *vivencia* has no direct English equivalent, it describes a way of knowing rooted in life experience and authentic participation. It dissolves the boundaries between oppressor and oppressed, academic and non-academic, theory and lived wisdom (Fals-Borda, 2007). *Vivencias* cannot simply be observed; they must be lived, felt, and experienced (Glassman and Erdem, 2014).

Through their *vivencias*, these women used art-making as a tool to reflect, raise awareness, rebuild personal and collective confidence, and sustain resistance. Their stories also offer insight into alternative forms of transdisciplinary collaboration (Merçon, 2021), where academics and community members become co-creators in a shared struggle, transforming research into a space of mutual recognition and dialogue.

Situating the Stories

The three stories presented in this chapter are rooted in the armed conflict that has plagued Colombia for more than seven decades (Niño González, 2017), making it one of the longest-running internal conflicts in Abya Yala. There is no consensus on when this internal conflict began, nor on its specific causes. Various studies on violence in Colombia point to a wide array of political, social, cultural, economic, and even religious factors. However, most agree that the violence escalated in 1946 with the return of the Conservative Party to power (Vázquez Piñeros, 2007). Just two years later, tensions exploded into full-scale civil war following the assassination of the Liberal political leader Jorge Eliécer Gaitán on April 9, 1948 (Archila Neira, 1995; LeGrand, 1997; Vázquez Piñeros, 2007).

This civil war led to the emergence of left-wing guerrilla groups such as the Revolutionary Armed Forces of Colombia (FARC) and the National Liberation Army (ELN). During this period, the burgeoning drug trade further intensified the conflict, driven by growing demand from the United States (Cruz and Rojas Rivera, 2008; Sáenz Rovner, 2009). The immense profits generated by narcotrafficking led to the formation of powerful cartels and the proliferation of hitman gangs (Cruz and Rojas Rivera, 2008). In the late 1970s, the United States supported the establishment of paramilitary groups aimed at countering communism in the region (Rivera, 2007). Over time, landowners and business elites also utilised these groups to protect their economic interests (Rivera, 2007). Paramilitaries were further employed to forcibly acquire land for the development of megaprojects, the expansion of African palm monocultures, and large-scale cattle ranching (Oslender, 2004). These overlapping dynamics have made the conflict increasingly complex and difficult to resolve.

The conflict has generated widespread chaos and devastation, particularly in rural areas. Two of the regions most severely affected are the coastal areas, which have historically been, and remain, inhabited primarily by Afro-descendant communities (Castaño, 2015; Colectivo OFB & REDHPANA, 2021).

The armed conflict in Colombia, marked by the collaboration of the state, has left countless victims. Those deeply moved by the conflict are rural, Afro-Colombian and Indigenous people, and women are the most affected (Rosa Margarita, 2014; Santis Vellojín and Mira González, 2020).

The armed conflict in Colombia, often marked by state complicity, has left a vast number of victims. Among those most deeply affected are rural populations, Afro-Colombian and Indigenous peoples, with women bearing the brunt of the violence (Rosa Margarita, 2014; Santis Vellojín and Mira González, 2020). According to official figures, 9,218,796 people have been registered as victims of the armed conflict, of whom 4,506,719 are women (Unidad para la Atención y la Reparación Integral a las Víctimas, 2021). Women have been systematically targeted by all armed groups, suffering

displacement from their territories, loss of family members, sexual violence, forced disappearances, and illegal recruitment (Rosa Margarita, 2014; Santis Vellojín and Mira González, 2020). It is within this complex and painful context that the following stories are situated.

The First Story: Costureras por la Paz

Virgelina Chará, a war-displaced Afro-Colombian woman leader and human rights defender, was nominated for the Nobel Peace Prize in 2005 for her tireless work supporting women and displaced families, victims of Colombia's prolonged armed conflict. A multifaceted and resilient woman, Virgelina uses music, poetry, embroidery, and food as tools to denounce injustice, reconstruct history, and weave bonds of solidarity and hope.

Afro-Colombian and Indigenous communities from the Pacific region have long suffered forced displacement due to armed conflict, drug trafficking, the plundering of natural resources, and the advance of multinational megaprojects. Virgelina is among the countless victims of these intersecting forces. Her first displacement occurred in 1985 in the name of "development", when the construction of a hydroelectric dam in the municipality of Suárez, in Colombia's Pacific region, forced hundreds of Afro-descendant and Indigenous families from their ancestral lands (Pérez Lugo and Díaz Escandón, 2017). Virgelina, along with more than 200 families, fled to Cali, a city that has become a refuge for thousands of displaced Afro-Colombians. There, she struggled to survive and care for her seven children, selling fruit on the streets to make ends meet.

Even amidst this struggle, she became a community leader, fighting alongside others to secure housing for the displaced and protect their children from illegal recruitment by armed groups. However, for daring to speak out and denounce state abandonment, Virgelina and other community leaders were branded as guerrillas and received death threats from paramilitary groups (personal conversation, October 2020).

In 2003, to save her life, she fled once again, this time to Bogotá (Medina Abad, 2021). There, she founded *Asomujer y Trabajo*, a grassroots organisation working with and for victims of the armed conflict, particularly women displaced by violence. Her work focused on promoting human rights and empowering women through education and training. Over time, Virgelina became an expert on victims' rights. With support from professors, researchers, and activists, she helped influence public policy through advocacy efforts within the National Victims Board. Together with fellow leaders, she co-authored a document compiling the various laws relating to victims' rights, many of which were later incorporated into Law 1448 of 2011: the Victims and Land Restitution Law. Although the law promises comprehensive care, assistance, and reparations for victims, many remain unable to rebuild their lives or return to their ancestral territories (Sanabria Rodelo, 2018).

In 2008, a group of 40 victims of the armed conflict envisioned a powerful act of resistance, covering the Justice Palace in Bogotá with embroidered fabrics that told stories of violence. One of these groups, the *Unión de Costureros*, was led by Virgelina. Through

embroidery, they sought to reconstruct Colombia's historical memory and create spaces of healing, remembrance, and resistance. With colourful threads and pieces of cloth, victims broke the silence, healed wounds, rewrote national history, and rebuilt fractured relationships. They sang songs of resistance and peace, stitching together their pain, hopes, and dreams.

The *Unión de Costureros* became a space for collective exchange and learning, where students, professors, neighbours, and international visitors converge. Today, the space remains open to anyone interested in (re)writing Colombia's history and building the long-awaited peace. Embroidery is accompanied by talks, songs, and deep reflections. Over the years, hundreds have participated, contributing their stories and building an alternative narrative of Colombian history. Supported by various institutions, including universities (Atehortúa, 2019), the *Unión de Costureros* has transformed into a classroom of memory and a laboratory of co-creation, where victims, researchers, activists, and institutions collectively search for alternatives to war and pathways to social justice.

Second Story: The Tejedoras of Mampuján

This is the story of Juana Alicia Ruiz and a group of women from Mampuján, who won Colombia's National Peace Prize in 2015 for their work in the peacebuilding process in the Montes de María region (Ramos Díaz Granados, 2018).

Mampuján is a township located in the Montes de María region, a jungle area near Colombia's Caribbean coast, rich in natural resources. Yet, like many others, this region has suffered from state neglect and the persistent presence of illegal armed groups. The conflict in Montes de María resulted in 57 massacres (Comisión de la Verdad, 2020), the displacement of thousands, and widespread violence that bore witness to the brutality of war. Only 15 days after one of the bloodiest massacres in the country's history, in which more than 100 people were killed, including a 6-year-old girl in the town of El Salado, the paramilitaries arrived in Mampuján (Rubio, 2012).

Between March 10 and 11, 2000, the so-called *Bloque Héroes de los Montes de María* of the *Autodefensas Unidas de Colombia* (AUC) continued their trail of terror, forcibly displacing 245 families and murdering 13 people in the nearby village of Las Brisas (Rubio, 2012; Ruiz Hernández et al., 2019). That day marked the beginning of immense suffering for the inhabitants, caused by the loss of loved ones, land, crops, and property. But the most profound pain came from the uncertainty and forced exile. Their economic situation quickly deteriorated without access to land or employment. Hunger, unemployment, and disease generated instability, mistrust, and a breakdown of the social fabric, which soon led to domestic violence (Ruiz Hernández et al., 2019).

Four years after the displacement, and deeply concerned about the women's situation, Juana Alicia Ruiz, a teacher, nutritionist, and community leader, sought help. The women

eventually met Teresa Geiser, a Canadian psychologist who used quilting as a therapeutic tool (Ramos Díaz Granados, 2018). Geiser's method involved creating patchwork quilts with geometric shapes. The act of cutting fabric symbolised cutting away pain, and piercing the fabric with a needle was a metaphor for releasing that pain (Ruiz Hernández et al., 2016).

Initially, Juana encouraged more than 30 women to participate in the quilting sessions. Although the activity allowed them to gather and connect, the women felt that the geometric patterns lacked personal meaning. So Juana, along with other women, proposed a shift, replacing abstract shapes with landscapes and stories from their region. Thus, the Mampuján tapestries were born. The women began to visually narrate their lives, particularly their experiences of displacement. As they wove, they shared their stories, gradually healing their wounds, regaining self-confidence, and rebuilding community ties (Ruiz, 2018).

In 2005, the Colombian government enacted the Justice and Peace Law to facilitate the demobilisation of paramilitary groups. Its objective was to establish judicial, administrative, social, and economic measures to benefit victims of international humanitarian law violations (Ley 975, 2005). This law offered new hope to displaced families from Mampuján. In 2006, led by Juana Ruiz and supported by various institutions, the women created an organisation called *Asociación para la Vida Digna y Solidaria* – ASVIDAS (Ramos Díaz Granados, 2018; Ruiz Hernández et al., 2016).

Since then, the women of Mampuján have initiated various efforts, using quilting to preserve historical memory and heal from the trauma of war in Montes de María, while also developing food products. Their lived experiences (*vivencias*) are reflected in their tapestries, some of which are now exhibited in Colombia's National Museum (Sanabria Rodelo, 2018).



Figure 1. A handcrafted creation by the women of *Mujeres Tejiendo Sueños y Sabores de Paz* (2016).

With support from the United Nations, the women received funding for a project titled *La Ruta por la Vida* (The Route for Life), aimed at sharing their experience and knowledge in communities ravaged by paramilitary violence. They walked the same paths once marked by terror, now spreading hope and healing. At the same time, with the backing of national and international organisations, the community became increasingly empowered, advocating for truth, justice, and reparation in line with international humanitarian law.

Although unfamiliar with legal processes, the women began attending meetings and forums to understand and participate in reparation proceedings under the Justice and Peace Law. Communities across Montes de María organised marches, protests, legal actions, and advocacy campaigns to demand the rights promised to victims (Ruiz Hernández et al., 2016). It wasn't until 2014, however, that the reparation measures outlined in the Victims Law began to be implemented (Ramos Díaz Granados, 2018; Sanabria Rodelo, 2018).

Today, the Tejedoras of Mampuján continue to share their journey with women in other conflict-affected regions of Colombia. Their story is one of collective resilience, a process in which women have transformed quilting into a political act of (re)construction, (re)signification, and (re)creation of life, community bonds, and history. Through art, the women of Mampuján have begun to rebuild their lives and foster hope in other communities.

They have also diversified their efforts, integrating organic food production and small businesses to generate income while deepening their commitment to peacebuilding in Colombia (Garzón Martínez, 2020). The Tejedoras have collaborated with academics, researchers, activists, artists, and entrepreneurs, yet ownership of the process has always remained with the women themselves (Ruiz Hernández et al., 2019).

Third Story: Las Cantadoras del Pacífico Sur

This story unfolds on Colombia's Pacific coast, a region that spans more than 10 million hectares of tropical forest (Oslender, 2004). Recognised as one of the most biodiverse areas in the world, it is home to around one million Afro-descendants who have preserved much of their cultural heritage (Oslender, 2004). One of the most powerful ways these communities transmit knowledge and tradition is through song and poetry, which accompany every phase of life. Women sing to mark births, funerals, religious services, patronal festivals, and community gatherings.

In 1993, Colombia passed Law 70, officially recognising the collective territorial rights of rural Black communities and protecting their ethnic and cultural diversity. Paradoxically, just as their ancestral rights were legally affirmed, the armed conflict spread to their territories. These communities soon became the targets of various armed groups (Oslender, 2004), bringing fear and pain. According to Pinilla Bahamón (2017), the violence affected many traditional practices, including *alabaos*, rituals sung at funerals. Restrictions on movement imposed by armed actors, along with widespread displacement, prevented communities from properly mourning their dead, threatening the survival of these sacred customs and the knowledge they carry.

The Ombudsman's Office and the Consultancy for Human Rights and Displacement (CODHES) have reported that for over two decades, Colombia's Pacific region has suffered the highest rates of forced displacement in the country (CIVP, 2021; CODHES, 2020). Between January 2018 and February 2019 alone, CODHES recorded 20,850 displaced persons from the region (CODHES, 2020). Analysts and activists agree that this crisis stems from a convergence of powerful economic interests, including African palm plantations, large-scale infrastructure projects, and drug trafficking (Escobar, 2004; Oslender, 2004). This violence has deeply transformed the social and environmental fabric. Yet, the communities have forged powerful forms of resistance, creating networks and alliances to confront the terror of war (Lozano-Lerma, 2017; Oslender, 2003, 2004; Quiceno-Toro et al., 2017; Riaño-Alcalá and Chaparro-Pacheco, 2020). As Betty Lozano (2017) aptly notes, "everything in the Pacific is done collectively", including the story of the *Red de Cantadoras del Pacífico Sur* (RCPS).

For 13 years, the RCPS, a network of roughly 220 Afro-descendant women artists, has built a protective wall of song across several municipalities in Colombia's Pacific region (Guerrero, 2019b). The network was born from an act of reciprocity, as described by its director, anthropologist Paola Navia (Guerrero, 2019a). Originally from Tumaco, Paola conducted her graduate research on traditional music, focusing on women's *cantadoras* groups in her hometown. Between 2006 and 2007, she connected with seven such groups, most of them composed of elderly women. Through sharing life stories and songs, a powerful bond was formed. To give back, Paola sought support to help these women realise their dreams (Guerrero, 2019a).

In 2008, during the launch of the Colombian Ministry of Culture's policy for the South Pacific, Paola presented the work of these seven *cantadoras* groups. Captivated, the Minister encouraged her to expand the initiative across the entire Pacific region. This marked the birth of the RCPS. Since then, the network has participated in numerous festivals and recorded three albums. More importantly, it has created spaces for dialogue and exchange, strengthened intergenerational ties, and launched research and educational initiatives to safeguard the region's rich cultural heritage (Martinez, 2020). Children and youth have inherited these traditions, giving rise to new generations of *cantadoras*, poets, and artists. Through their music, these women preserve cultural memory and wield song as a form of peaceful resistance (Lozano-Mancera, 2017).

Beyond music, the network has nurtured social cohesion, healing, and resilience (Guerrero, 2019b). The *cantadoras* have transformed their chants into instruments of protest and healing (Pinilla-Bahamón, 2017). Their compositions call for peace and advocate for solutions to violence and poverty (Guerrero, 2019b). With spirituality, tradition, and voice, they go far beyond music; they weave their songs into threads of social reconstruction and transformation.

Each *cantadoras* group also serves as a training space where elders, youth, midwives, musicians, cultural workers, and academics converge. Here, young people learn the music and traditions of their ancestors, share stories, and train to become social and political leaders who defend their rights and strengthen community bonds (Guerrero, 2019a). Like the previous stories, these women complement their musical efforts with culinary ventures. These initiatives generate income, improve living conditions, and celebrate traditional Pacific cuisine.

This powerful transformation has been built through collaboration: academics, policy makers, and local communities have all played a role in supporting the *cantadoras* network. In 2021, to commemorate the International Day of Women Human Rights Defenders, the group composed a song titled *Cantamos por la Libertad* ("We Sing for Freedom"). It has since become an anthem among women, a collective cry for peace with social justice.

Here is an English version of the full song "Cantamos por la Libertad" that stays true to the poetic rhythm and powerful spirit of the original Spanish version:

We Sing for Freedom

*We are diverse women, woven together by sisterhood
It is a cry for life and for our mother, freedom.
I have the right to my people, to my river and to my sea.
Let no one kill our dreams; we sing for liberty.
I have the right to my land, my mountains and identity
To freely raise my voice, we sing for liberty.*

*I have the right to life, I have the right to be free
To walk upon my land, without fearing death will find me.
I have the right to speak out, to take part and to be seen
Our bodies and our dignity deserve respect and serenity.*

*No more violations of the rights we hold dear
The right to life, to land, to live in peace,
without fear. I have the right to dream, to build peace hand in hand.*

To stay rooted in my culture and not be forced from my land.

Arising from Art, Struggles and Resistance

Although the three stories described above did not originate as collaborative research projects, they illustrate alternative forms of transdisciplinary collaboration born from the lived struggles within the territories (Escobar, 2016). These stories also inspire potential pathways for decentralising knowledge production by generating collectively situated knowledge and transforming *vivencias* into art.

Drawing inspiration from these narratives, three key elements emerge that can support the decolonisation and (re)creation of collaborative research practices. First, knowledge, action, and resistance can arise from lived experiences, offering grounded insights that challenge dominant academic paradigms. Second, art and the process of art-making can serve as powerful tools for transformation, healing, and community-building. Finally, *vivencias* can play a central role in de-centring and diversifying knowledge production, shifting the focus from extractive approaches to more inclusive and reciprocal forms of knowledge co-creation.

Knowledge, Action and Resistance Emerge from Lived Experiences

A shared characteristic across the three cases is the interweaving of lived experiences, resistance, and knowledge production. Knowledge is generated through the collective (re)construction of *vivencias*, which strengthens social cohesion. In all three stories, knowledge is not pursued for its own sake (Louis, 2007); rather, it serves as a way of understanding reality, which, in turn, becomes a means of transforming it. Throughout the narratives, action, reflection, and transformation are dynamically intertwined. Paulo Freire (1970) describes this synergy as *praxis*, a process where action is fundamental to the production of knowledge.

This experiential knowledge emerges through face-to-face encounters rooted in empathy and resonance (Heron and Reason, 2008). It arises from struggles that are social, territorial, and centred on survival (Escobar, 2016; Fals-Borda, 2015; Santos, 2018). Santos (2018) argues that knowledge born from struggle offers a powerful means to decolonise knowledge production through sense-driven engagements with multiple worlds. It acknowledges that knowledge is a corporeal activity involving all the senses and necessitates a deep, affective experience, one that enables the transformation of the world. This kind of knowledge is deeply contextual, embodied, and remembered. It is shaped by emotional and intense expressions of feeling, anchored in storied, relational,

and intimate places (Styres, 2019).

Struggle also functions as a tool of collective agency, turning the awareness of injustice into strategies for resistance and transformation (Smith, 2012). In the three cases, women draw upon their *vivencias* to build critical consciousness (Freire, 1970). This action-reflection process enables them to forge collective strategies of resistance. Revisiting their lived experiences and (re)constructing collective memory becomes a means to confront the violence they have endured. Non-written forms of knowledge, such as music, poetry, and tapestry, play a central role in shaping political consciousness and creating spaces of resistance against violent dynamics (Lozano-Mancera, 2017; Oslender, 2003). These spaces also reaffirm ethnic and cultural identities, giving rise to new pedagogies of resistance grounded in art, music, and culinary traditions.

In the context of transdisciplinary collaborations, linking knowledge, action, and resistance necessitates the decolonisation and de-centring of knowledge production. This shift involves moving from problem-based to struggle-based research (Valenzuela-Fuentes, 2019) and replacing extractive research practices with transformative, creative, and committed dialogues that align with the realities of communities. It also requires humility, responsibility, and generosity from researchers, especially the willingness to relinquish control and allow communities to guide the research process.

Art and Art-Making as Transformative Tools

Art plays a pivotal role in decolonising knowledge production (Santos, 2018), fostering healing (Rathwell and Armitage, 2016), and enabling transformation (Steelman et al., 2019) across the three stories. Through art, new knowledge is produced by integrating historical, symbolic, and epistemic elements. Art is also a medium for expressing emotion, denouncing injustice, and reviving ancestral traditions. At the same time, the collective process of making art provides an opportunity to share lived experiences and reshape community relationships.

Artistic expressions such as songs, embroidery, and tapestry are powerful ways through which women represent, conceptualise, and interpret their experiences beyond the confines of discursive language. Yet this knowledge is not merely representational (Heron and Reason, 2008); it weaves together spirituality, solidarity, and diverse worldviews through threads, poems, verses, and melodies. These art forms serve as tools for reconstructing historical memory and linking the past with the present and the future. Women's lived experiences, emotions, and resistance are interlaced like fine, twisted fibres, while the act of weaving strengthens communal ties.

As Juana Ruiz shared in an interview (Ruiz, 2018), women are not only weaving threads, they are weaving new personal and collective narratives, stitching peace and envisioning a

better future for themselves and their families. Initially, the goal was to heal the wounds of forced displacement, and art proved vital in this process. It enabled the transformation of pain into creativity, creating a safe communal space for healing. For Virgelina Chará, healing is also bound to the pursuit of truth. The collective construction of tapestries offers a space for reconstructing truth from the victims' perspectives. Through these shared acts of creation, healing and collective transformation take place, fostering social change.

According to Freire (1970), overcoming oppression begins with a critical understanding of its causes, which then enables transformative action. In all three stories, the women reflect on their lived realities as they (re)write their stories and (re)invent new ways to address ongoing challenges. Artistic creation becomes a unique language that bridges past, present, and future (Steelman et al., 2019), integrating knowledge, practices, and beliefs (Rathwell and Armitage, 2016). It is also a vehicle for transformation, opening doors to economic opportunities, leadership roles, social recognition, and enhanced self-worth. These transformations occur at both personal and collective levels. As women grow stronger individually, their families and communities become more resilient. This transformation empowers them to face new forms of violence by drawing on a combination of art, solidarity, and spirituality.

In the stories highlighted in this chapter, art is not a research method employed by academics for data collection. Instead, art and the act of creating art serve as: (i) a means through which communities (re)construct, (re)present, and (re)signify lived experiences and knowledge; (ii) a bridge between individual and collective struggles that are transformed into strategies of resistance; and (iii) a language that connects diverse forms of knowledge, praxis, and spirituality (Rathwell and Armitage, 2016).

Vivencias as a Pathway to De-Centring and Diversifying Knowledge Production.

Decolonising knowledge production requires displacing the centrality of Western reasoning (Ahenakew, 2016). It involves rethinking the purpose of knowledge creation, the means through which knowledge is obtained, and the role of the researcher in this process. To truly decolonise knowledge, the academic monopoly on epistemology must be dismantled, allowing for onto-epistemic diversity to flourish (Grosfoguel, 2013; Santos, 2014). The stories explored in this chapter illustrate how this can be achieved from within, by centring lived experiences and community-led initiatives.

These stories originate not from academic inquiry but from women's lived realities and their mobilisation in response to violence and displacement. Their journeys toward healing and justice give rise to knowledge grounded in struggle. As they take the first steps, others join, contributing their own experiences, tools, and understandings. Together, they form networks of learning and solidarity, using art as a shared language. Through this praxis of solidarity (Gaztambide-Fernández, 2012), external actors,

researchers, policymakers, and educators do not lead but accompany and support. The initiatives remain rooted in the communities and are led by women who are reclaiming agency and shaping change.

In the case of the Cantadoras del Pacífico Sur, a network emerges from a researcher's act of reciprocity. She brings her skills into service for the women and their communities. Yet it is the cantadoras, midwives, and wise women who lead the processes, establishing schools where ancestral knowledge and cultural traditions are passed down to new generations. Art becomes a vehicle not only for healing but also for resistance, empowerment, and intergenerational renewal. Government agencies, musicians, and educators contribute, but always in support of the women's leadership and the cultural grounding of their work.

The story of the Tejedoras of Mampuján offers a different entry point. Their journey begins with a psychologist who introduces them to quilting as a way to process the trauma of forced displacement. This practice, initially therapeutic, evolves into a powerful method for reconstructing personal and collective narratives. It becomes a tool for social healing and transformation, empowering women to share their stories across the country and beyond. Their success draws academics from around the world to learn from the lived knowledge of Afro-descendant women who have turned their once-overlooked town into a site of epistemic significance.

Virgelina's story presents yet another pathway. A displaced Afro-descendant woman, she moves from selling fruit on the streets to speaking in universities and policy forums about the realities of victims. Like the Tejedoras, she transforms quilting into a medium of denunciation, consciousness-raising, and solidarity. She galvanises international attention, mobilising scholars, institutions, and policymakers to acknowledge the harm caused by the armed conflict in Colombia and to work toward justice and non-repetition. Her story is a testament to the transformative power of embodied knowledge and resistance.

The knowledge produced through these vivencias, these life experiences rooted in struggle (Santos, 2018), revives and validates what dominant epistemologies have historically sought to erase. These stories challenge the hierarchical role of the academic, inviting instead a collaborative dialogue between traditional and scholarly knowledge instead. In this space, researchers do not impose solutions but join in weaving knowledge, solidarity, and hope. The co-creation of new knowledge happens in praxis, not in isolation. Through lived experience, artistic expression, and collective memory, knowledge becomes an instrument of social transformation, deeply contextual, embodied, and alive.

Concluding Remarks

There is a growing recognition that knowledge production must transcend intellectual exercise and instead serve as a means for self-emancipation and collective liberation (Fals-Borda and Rahman, 1991; Louis, 2007; Smith, 2012). Concurrently, the imperative to decolonise, de-centre, and de-privilege dominant epistemologies is gaining momentum. The *vivencias* explored in this chapter exemplify how women, drawing from their lived experiences, engage in reciprocal learning and use art as a transformative tool to (re)construct histories, heal wounds, resist oppression, and foster a sense of collective identity

These *vivencias*, born out of struggle, become vibrant expressions of emancipatory praxis. Transformed into art, they create critical spaces that (re)value and centre diverse ways of knowing, spaces where personal pain is converted into collective strength and resistance. Through songs, weavings, and other creative forms, women reflect on their realities, challenge structural violence, and co-create narratives of peace and possibility. In doing so, they not only reimagine their futures but also inspire new relational modes of knowledge production, anchored in solidarity, spirituality, and lived experience.

This collaborative and embodied process fosters dialogue across epistemic boundaries, encouraging mutual learning and the co-creation of contextually grounded knowledge. It is in this weaving of lives, stories, and worldviews that transformation becomes possible, on both personal and community levels.

I hope that the reflections shared in this chapter will inspire researchers and practitioners to (re)imagine and (re)invent more inclusive and transformative forms of transdisciplinary collaboration, ones that contribute meaningfully to sustainable social change and peaceful coexistence in diverse territories.

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Chapter 3

Cartographies from the South: Lessons Learned from the Co-creation of Knowledge among Indigenous Peoples in Northeastern Brazil

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Abstract

This chapter explores the lessons drawn from three participatory cartography projects developed in collaboration with Indigenous communities in northeastern Brazil. These groups share a historical trajectory as inhabitants of the first region colonised by the Portuguese, enduring over 500 years of colonial influence and resistance. The first project, co-produced with the Tupinambá people, resulted in a web documentary that served as a tool for amplifying their struggle. The second initiative engaged eight Indigenous communities in the implementation of a public policy aimed at strengthening cultural practices. The third project, a postgraduate academic course and research initiative, provided a theoretical framework that informed both earlier efforts. By sharing key insights from these experiences in the Global South through a decolonial lens, we contribute to ongoing discussions on the necessity of transdisciplinary approaches to today's complex socio-environmental challenges. We highlight three critical lessons: the advantages of co-creating knowledge with organised social movements, strategies for navigating power dynamics within collaborative projects, and the importance of language and visual representation as integral elements of decolonial research. Ultimately, we reaffirm that engaged research, conducted in direct collaboration with movements advocating for environmental, social, and cultural diversity, has the potential to reshape scientific practice and advance a more sustainable and equitable future.

Keywords: Decolonial thinking · Participatory mapping · Indigenous movement · Brazil

Introduction

This chapter presents lessons learned from three participatory cartography projects developed in collaboration with Indigenous peoples in northeastern Brazil. These transdisciplinary initiatives emerged at the intersection of art, science, and activism, united by a shared goal: to support Indigenous communities in their material and symbolic struggles for recognition.

The reflections outlined here stem from activities encompassing artistic exchanges between traditional and contemporary culture makers, academic research, and the implementation of public policy. Throughout these engagements, we remained acutely aware of the political dimensions of research and the need to challenge the prevailing notion that social science is the sole legitimate translator of social and cultural

phenomena, a notion rooted in the separation between subject and object, often materialised in the colonial triad: "observe-know-conquer."

Rejecting any claim to universality, we sought to create spaces where dialogues among diverse subjects could unfold as freely as possible. We do not intend, nor would it be possible, to present every step and shared moment of the three projects. Instead, we have chosen to prioritise the transversal possibilities and limitations that emerged from reflecting on these encounters, in the hope of inspiring new paths for "committed research" and offering tools for knowledge co-production that contribute to the transformations needed for sustainability.

We aim to amplify the practices emerging from the Global South, both in terms of academic engagement and environmental justice movements. Power structures in knowledge production and circulation tend to overshadow alternatives built in the South (Pereira et al., 2020), even though transformative actions continue to flourish where movements of resistance create territories of life beyond the oppression of people and nature. We wish to *outscale*, rather than *upscale* (Temper et al., 2018), our learnings alongside the intense life and struggles of the Indigenous peoples with whom we worked. Our goal is to share adaptation tools that we encountered on our journey through the dense Brazilian Atlantic Rainforest, in the hope that they may also be useful in other territories similarly impacted by coloniality.

We start from the premise that the subalternisation of peoples and territories in Latin America, and other regions at the peripheries of the world, is not confined to the colonial period, but persists through ongoing colonialities of power, knowledge, being, and seeing, forces that continue to shape current forms of oppression and resistance (Castro-Gómez and Grosfoguel, 2007; Barriandos, 2011).

Drawing from this background and our experiences, we first position our arguments within current literature, identifying echoes of decolonial thinking in Latin America that call for knowledge co-production as a pathway toward transformations to sustainability. Next, we describe the methodological and territorial contours of the three projects we co-created with Indigenous peoples of northeastern Brazil. We then provide a brief historical overview of the Indigenous groups involved and offer succinct descriptions of each of the three cartographies.

Most importantly, we present three sets of lessons learned from those experiences, namely: (i) the benefits we recognised of co-creating knowledge with organised social movements; (ii) tips about challenges in dealing with power relations inside the projects; and (iii) the importance of reflecting on language and visualities as part of decolonial research practice.

We conclude by reaffirming that committed research, conducted in direct collaboration with movements advocating for environmental, social, and cultural diversity, can significantly transform both the way we practice science and the construction of a

more sustainable future.

Co-production of Knowledge through Decolonial Lenses

Extensive literature has advocated for transdisciplinary processes to generate new shared scientific perspectives for sustainability (Lang et al., 2012). We understand transdisciplinarity as the co-production of knowledge that involves not only different epistemological backgrounds and scientific disciplines but also a collective commitment to produce solutions to societal problems (Hadorn et al., 2008). The uncertainty surrounding environmental crises such as biodiversity loss and climate change demands new forms of rationality, relationality, and thinking that move beyond evidence-based approaches (Beier et al., 2016).

Transdisciplinarity initially addresses disciplinary boundaries within academia, promoting complex knowledge production on the multiple dimensions of socio-environmental systems. It then extends to recognise the importance of integrating non-academic knowledge. Following this trajectory, most sustainability scientists today acknowledge the need to address power structures underpinning knowledge production through self-reflectiveness (Fazey et al., 2018; Schneider et al., 2019).

However, much of the research that embraces this critique still operates within the framework of technocratic solutions, often restricting "practical knowledge" to perspectives rooted in the same epistemological foundations as modern science, such as State policies and technological innovation. Knowledge co-production, in this sense, is often limited to scientists, managers, and select civil society organisations, without properly questioning who controls the use and access to natural resources, especially in contexts shaped by coloniality. Many research and implementation projects for sustainability work with "aligned partners," that is, groups with shared norms and interests capable of relating to a particular formulation of problems and solutions (Marin et al., 2016). While systemic approaches to transformation generate positive outcomes, as Scoones et al. (2019) observe, they must be complemented with structural and enabling approaches that place politics at the centre of transformation, especially within violent and coloniality-marked environments. In such settings, simple sustainability metrics and consensual agreements often prove inadequate.

Following Temper et al. (2018), we argue for greater recognition of the insights and practices emerging from environmental justice movements and scholars who have long championed their transformative power (Martinez Alier, 2007; Escobar, 2008).

In other words, while significant parts of the transformation literature acknowledge the importance of power relations in knowledge production, they fail to advance a true decolonial epistemological turn (Castro-Gomez and Grosfoguel, 2007). We build on Latin American decolonial thinking to advocate for research from a "committed" point of view:

research as a means of forging alliances with historically marginalised voices and perspectives. We understand "committed research" as the production of thought and methodologies that challenge unjust social structures that perpetuate racism, elitism, sexism, and homophobia. This requires critical examination of the role of the researcher and the hierarchical valuation of knowledge based on geography and localised practices.

Committed research must aim to combat inequalities and dismantle the asymmetries of power that enable knowledge production to perpetuate domination, in other words, coloniality, particularly within universities. Without engaging with the theories and movements that emerge from struggles for environmental justice, social equality, and cultural recognition, it is not possible to break free from the constraints of coloniality. We embrace the tension between academia and community by calling for a methodological shift that allies research with historically silenced lives, knowledge systems, and perspectives (Lugones, 2018).

Thus, we argue that a decolonial turn in research and political action in Latin America can significantly contribute to committed research towards transformation by deeply confronting power relations in knowledge production.

The concept of "coloniality" captures the enduring processes of subordination in the peripheries of the world-system, such as Latin America, representing the systematically hidden yet essential underside of modernity (Quijano, 2000; Mignolo, 2017). As Alimonda (2011) observes, the catastrophic trauma of conquest has historically unified Latin America. Despite resistance, the oppression of both people and nature has continued to expand over the centuries. Coloniality did not end with the formation of nation-states in Latin America, Africa, or Asia. Rather, the hierarchical structures established during the colonial period persist today, albeit in new forms (Castro-Gomez and Grosfoguel, 2007).

Therefore, to meaningfully engage with territories such as northeastern Brazil, the heart of Latin America's Atlantic coast, it is crucial to create spaces for epistemological diversity and to maintain a critical stance toward modernity and its knowledge systems. Here, we focus specifically on the "coloniality of knowledge": the Eurocentric perspective that glorifies modernity and portrays the Western tradition as the pinnacle of cultural evolution (Lander, 2005). The pluriverse of Latin American realities continues to be colonised through the interplay of power and knowledge, which produces dominant discourses that constrain alternative visions and limit transformative possibilities (Escobar, 2007).

In our practice, we engage with knowledge pathways shaped since the late 1990s and early 2000s, when new political subjects and social movements emerged across Latin America. These movements, including women, youth, Indigenous peoples, landless workers, LGBTQ+ communities, and hackers, have generated new constellations of meaning and practices linked to a "politics of life" (Tarin, 2015).

Many research and political action initiatives in Latin America have employed cartography, or participatory mapping, as a tool to support these movements, providing visibility to their knowledge systems and demands for justice. These counter-mappings rearticulate the relationships among territory, identity, and rights, resulting in diverse experiments and reflections (Sandroni and Tarin, 2021). A key lesson from these experiences is the importance of participation and protagonism in determining what a map should represent, whether cognitive or geographic. While participatory mapping can empower historically silenced populations, it can also inadvertently legitimise authoritarian actions if not carefully approached (Acserald, 2012).

Thus, decolonial cartographies must engage with two key questions: (1) who maps, why, and how; and (2) what does the map make visible, and what does it communicate to different audiences? These questions can only be meaningfully addressed through embodied interactions. In moving toward the material dimension of our work, it is therefore essential to bring our arguments to life by describing the contours of Indigenous movements in northeastern Brazil and the specificities of the three co-created projects.

By grounding our discussion in the political, socio-economic, and cultural realities of these territories, we aim to move beyond subjugating research practices and challenge the epistemic coloniality that continues to marginalise and invalidate diverse ways of knowing.

Territorial Contours

Indigenous Peoples in Northeastern Brazil

All three projects were developed through sustained dialogue with members and leaders of Indigenous movements in northeastern Brazil. Despite the heterogeneity among these groups, they share a common reality: their territories lie in the first region colonised by the Portuguese. As such, they have endured over 500 years of material and symbolic oppression resulting from sustained colonial contact.

Among the many symbolic battles these communities face is a powerful narrative of "acculturation", repeatedly reinforced throughout Brazilian history. According to this colonial narrative, European colonisers allegedly "civilised" these Indigenous peoples in an irreversible manner, thereby stripping them of their indigeneity. As a result, many Brazilians, including academics, fail to recognise the continued existence of these communities, rendering them invisible in the public imagination.

This rhetoric of extinction continues to obstruct their struggles. These people are subjected not only to deep prejudice linked to their so-called "non-Indigenous" status but also to harmful stereotypes often projected onto Indigenous populations more broadly, such as being labelled lazy or incapable. They are frequently seen as impostors or

"utilitarian Indians," as "real" Indigenous peoples are presumed to be isolated and located only in the remote wilderness of the Amazon.

This distorted view stands in stark contrast to the vibrant resurgence of Indigenous identity and activism in the region, particularly over the past three decades. In 1991, approximately 56,000 individuals in the northeastern states identified as Indigenous in the official census (Oliveira, 2011). By 2010, this number had risen to about 210,000, and it is certainly higher today, although updated official data is not yet available.

To engage in projects related to these communities through decolonial lenses, we must begin by understanding their relationships with other groups, rather than viewing each community as a closed totality, as much of the Brazilian anthropological tradition has historically done. Their alterity arises not from isolation, but from contact, from the active construction of difference within symbolic interactions and through engagement with different hierarchical systems. This context has been described as "interethnic friction" (Poz, 2003), a concept that has informed much of the scientific support provided to Indigenous struggles.

It is also important to highlight that, in response to the Brazilian State's persistent failure to uphold the constitutional rights of Indigenous peoples to land use and occupation in the region, Indigenous movements are compelling the State to acknowledge their existence through processes of "self-demarcation." That is, many Indigenous groups in the Northeast are asserting their rights through what they call *retomadas*, acts of "taking back" what they know was historically usurped from them. These political actions are affirmed through both material and symbolic strategies (Oliveira, 2018).

On the material level, they occupy former farms that they consider part of their traditional territories, transforming social and physical landscapes once shaped by capitalist plantations. Regaining control of these lands allows them to revitalise their lifeways, fundamentally reconfiguring the prior socio-environmental systems of exclusion. Lands once degraded now become spaces for reforestation, agriculture, and the resurgence of cultural practices. Symbolically, these movements are also engaged in the revitalisation of their languages and cultures, crafting counter-narratives about their past and present (Tarin, 2017).

Many of these counter-narratives are developed in conjunction with New Information and Communication Technologies (NICTs), non-Indigenous allies, and committed scholars, particularly anthropologists, who support Indigenous efforts to dismantle the "acculturation paradigm" (Arruti, 1995; Oliveira, 1998; Alarcon, 2019). A central argument in this collaboration is that cultural encounters do not necessarily result in homogenisation; instead, they may generate new forms of difference, even within profoundly asymmetrical power relations. The Tupinambá, Potiguara, Pankararé, Fulni-Ô, and many other Indigenous peoples in the region continue to generate alterity and cultural heterogeneity through a history of multiple encounters, not isolation.

This notion is powerfully captured by the slogan printed on the T-shirts of young Indigenous leaders at the 2017 National Indigenous Students' Meeting: "*I can be who you are without ceasing to be who I am.*"

This underscores the fact that Indigenous struggles for environmental justice, cultural and territorial recognition, and diversity are complex and deeply interconnected: cultural expression and political activism are mutually reinforcing, constantly shaping one another in a context where it is impossible to disentangle the political contours of ethnic relations (Tarin et al., 2017). For Indigenous peoples in northeastern Brazil, living their culture is, above all, a political act. This is clearly articulated by Indigenous leader Joel Braz Pataxó:

"In the past, our ancestors fought in many ways. I always reflect on the forms of resistance they practised to preserve tradition, language, dance, food systems, the need to hunt, and to harvest shellfish. Maintaining those traditions is also a form of Indigenous life and resistance."

Recognising the interconnectedness of culture and political action also means acknowledging that memory is foundational to contemporary Indigenous lifeways. It is no coincidence that the oral histories currently told in these communities often recount the conflicts and victories of warriors who fought to preserve their ancestral practices and traditions.

Today, the Indigenous struggle resides both in memory and in the invention of new forms of resistance, both in political action and cultural practice. Through this fusion, Indigenous communities are actively re-establishing a favorable environment for sustaining their ways of life. These ways of life serve as both the spearhead of contemporary transformation and an enduring expression of ancient knowledge and cosmology. In the Indigenous lifeworlds of northeastern Brazil, past, present, and future are inseparably woven together.

This is particularly important in a country where alternatives to the dominant development model, which devastates the environment and entrenches systems of oppression, often appear scarce. In Brazil, as in much of Latin America, development policies remain closely tied to what scholars term the *extractive imperative*: a dependency on commodities, monoculture plantations, and mineral resource extraction as primary drivers of rural economic growth and global trade benefits (Arsel et al., 2016). This imperative has shaped land use and occupation patterns since the colonial era and has continued, largely unchallenged, even throughout Brazil's democratic history.

The situation has become markedly worse since the rise of an authoritarian right-wing government in 2018, which has escalated the violence inflicted on Indigenous peoples and the environment. We understand that any path out of Brazil's current socio-environmental crisis must include viable alternatives to historical extractivism and its modern iteration, *neo-extractivism*. One such alternative is found in the *ecoterritorial turn*, a concept that represents the innovative intersection between cultural diversity and

environmentalist approaches to territorial recognition (Svampa, 2019).

The ecoterritorial turn signals a profound shift in land struggles across Latin America, wherein territoriality and the specific cultural ways traditional populations relate to their environment become central (Guedes, 2013). This transformation is closely linked to the widespread use of participatory mapping, which marks a departure from earlier struggles based primarily on class and the universal right to access land. Instead, it advances claims grounded in ethnic identity and environmental justice, recognising these lifeways as critical to global sustainability.

Maps co-produced by scientists and Indigenous leaders serve as powerful symbolic instruments, tools of communication that reinforce these identities and the deep, reciprocal relationship between people and territory (Cáceres, 2012).

As an essential component of the ecoterritorial turn, ethnic mobilisations in northeastern Brazil do more than resist the expansion of homogenising, capitalist frontiers driven by neo-extractivism. They also catalyse a dynamic and ongoing process of (re)diversification of natural and cultural landscapes (Sandroni, 2018). In this sense, the struggles of Indigenous peoples in northeastern Brazil are generating not only local alternatives but also globally relevant responses to pressing ecological and social challenges.

It is worth emphasising that our research projects were shaped by a commitment to support and amplify these counter-narratives and to enhance their visibility. At the same time, we viewed our participation as an opportunity for learning, one that could enrich our own trajectories as scholars within the Brazilian social sciences and humanities.

Cartographies from the South

An Affective mapping: In the Roots of the Deep Clouds – Tupi-Alive*

The first project described here was co-produced with the Tupinambá Indigenous people of Olivença, located in the southern part of Bahia State, Brazil, during 2012 and 2013. It was supported by funding from the Brazilian National Foundation for the Arts (FUNARTE), through a public call designed to foster aesthetic interactions between contemporary artists and popular culture initiatives. The project aimed to generate a collaborative artistic work with the Tupinambá community that would enhance their capacity to flourish and assert political and cultural autonomy.

The Tupinambá of Olivença inhabit a territory that extends from the Atlantic coastline into the mountainous rainforest region of the Atlantic Forest. The village of Olivença was founded in 1680 by Jesuit missionaries, whose stated goal was to "educate and civilise the savages," marking the beginning of a long legacy of imposed domination and cultural erasure. By the late nineteenth century, the Tupinambá were officially considered extinct,

a presumption driven by the exclusionary logic of state institutions and the economic interests of local elites known as *coronéis*, or regional power brokers.

The 1988 Brazilian Constitution opened the legal space necessary for the recognition of Indigenous peoples such as the Tupinambá. In the late 1990s, particularly around the 500th anniversary of Brazil's colonisation in 2000, their movement for the demarcation of traditional territory gained momentum, reclaiming land and cultural identity that had been systematically stripped away. In 2001, the Tupinambá of Olivença were officially recognised by the National Indian Foundation (FUNAI), and in 2009, the Brazilian state published a preliminary map of their Indigenous Territory. However, the demarcation process was never finalised. It remains stalled in the Ministry of Justice, undermined by multiple revisions of territorial boundaries made to favour large cocoa producers and local landowning elites. Political and institutional resistance continues to obstruct ratification, with deadlines imposed by federal courts repeatedly ignored. Today, over 6,000 people reside in the Tupinambá territory, and their struggle for official recognition is ongoing.

In collaboration with Indigenous leaders and recognised by the community as both artists and committed researchers, we worked to create an artistic and communicative tool that would amplify the visibility of Tupinambá life and resistance, while also serving as a medium for self-recognition within the community. Our engagement was shaped by three interwoven layers: the structures of subordination imposed from outside; the processes of autonomy and self-worth cultivated within the community, both collectively and individually; and the dynamic forms of resistance that expand the limits of the possible and challenge existing oppression.

Together with the Indigenous movement, we identified core aspects of Tupinambá life to be addressed, along with the community members best positioned to speak to each theme. Interviews were conducted and combined with other materials collected during our time together, including literary writings, drawings, poetry, and culinary recipes, culminating in an artistic piece that could convey the richness and resilience of the Tupinambá experience.

The outcome was an interactive web documentary titled *Tupi-Vivo* ("Tupi-Alive"), a name that asserts the vitality of the Tupinambá struggle in contrast to decades of imposed invisibility. To ensure broader accessibility, especially given the limited internet connectivity in some parts of the territory, we also produced an analogue version of the project in the form of a poster. This visual map of relationships and networks within the Tupinambá territory was distributed directly in the communities, supporting both internal reflection and external communication of their ongoing journey.

B. Cartographic Routes: Indigenous Movements in the Northeast

The second project emerged from lived experiences during the implementation of a public policy aimed at forming a network among the Indigenous Points of Culture (IPCs) in northeastern Brazil in 2014. The Points of Culture were organisations involved in cultural activities and projects that were recognised and supported by the "Cultura Viva" (Living Culture) programme, implemented by the Brazilian federal government from 2004 to 2014. The IPCs were a specific adaptation of this policy tailored to projects rooted in Indigenous communities.

The implementation of the IPCs in the Northeast was managed by a local NGO through an agreement with the Brazilian Ministry of Culture. One of the first steps required by the policy was conducting a "current situation diagnosis" of the beneficiary communities. However, this so-called diagnosis was expected to be carried out through a quantitative survey containing questions that were extremely disconnected from Indigenous realities, such as "How many times do you go to the theatre per year?" or "What is the importance of cinema in your day-to-day life?"

As researchers invited to conduct this diagnosis, we proposed abandoning the questionnaire entirely and instead applying participatory mapping as our methodology to more appropriately address the complexities and contexts of the IPCs in the Northeast. Thus, this second cartographic initiative became part of a public policy effort, an act of 'subversive participatory planning' within the implementation process itself.

We invited Jaborandy Tupinambá, who had also worked with us on *Tupi-Alive*, to join the coordination team. Together, we embarked on a new journey across eight Indigenous territories: the Pankararu in the state of Pernambuco; the Kariri-Xocó and Karapotó Plaki-ô in Alagoas; the Xokó in Sergipe; and the Pataxó de Barra Velha, Pataxó da Aldeia Dois Irmãos, Pataxó Hãhãhãe, and Tupinambá de Olivença in Bahia.

In each community, we invited IPC participants to a workshop designed to surface and activate aspects of their cultural life that could either support or pose challenges to the development of their Points of Culture. As with the previous project, we collectively identified key themes to explore and selected individuals within the communities who could speak to those themes, this time with a more focused lens on cultural dynamics and within a more limited timeframe in each location.

The resulting cartography comprises eight segments (one per Indigenous people and IPC) and is structured in three distinct parts: an opening section inspired by each community's aspirations regarding their IPC; a second section composed entirely of transcribed Indigenous testimonies about factors that strengthen or hinder the IPCs; and a third, reflective section in which the speaker's identity is not clearly delineated, allowing for a shared narrative voice. In this final part, we developed texts that narrate powerful and diverse forms of resistance and cultural struggle led by these Indigenous groups.

This project culminated in the creation of a second interactive communication work. . Its analogue version was published as an illustrated book, extending the reach of these cartographies beyond digital access and into the hands of the communities themselves.

C. Cartographies in Academia: Mapping Brazilian cartographers

The third project was academic research that served as a theoretical base, a way to promote and discuss publicly projects A and B. The research aimed to carry out a careful bibliographical survey of the main researchers and research centers inside the humanities disciplines that mobilise the concepts of cartography and participatory mappings in Brazil. The goal was to recognise and publicise, in a systematic way, the debate on the possibilities and limits of cartography as a research method in the humanities to face the challenges of the epistemological turn that questions scientific objectivity and brings about research commitment. Thus, following the correlations drawn by published books and articles, we identified four main networks of research and cartographic practices. The first network is articulated around the 'Cartographies of Desires' engendered mainly by research centres based in psychology departments, whose unity rests on a common theoretical affinity with the thought of Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari (Passos et al., 2010; Passos et al., 2014).

The second network is activated by the application by Brazilian researchers, of a set of techniques developed by Brazilian researchers as a didactic version of the Actor-Network Theory entitled 'Cartography of Controversies', which is primarily used in the social communications departments (Lemos, 2011; 2013). The third network is composed of 'Social Cartographies', participatory geo-referenced mappings held by various researchers from urban planning to geography and anthropology in connection to Indigenous peoples, among other traditional populations and subaltern voices (Almeida, 2013; Acselrad, 2012). The fourth network is formed by the 'Cartographies of Action' and encompasses the connection between sociologists and geographers with urban and rural subaltern populations and their forms of self-representation (Ribeiro et al., 2011; Silva, 2011).

The comparative study was organised through the search for regularities and discontinuities in the 'cartographers' narratives, both in terms of method and matter of research. All these were organised and offered to the public in the format of an academic extension programme, fertilising and nurturing our practices and also contributing to others in their own implementation processes and research. Taking advantage of the possibilities brought by scientific inquiry at the theoretical level, we got the chance to combine systematic thinking with the specific openings of extra-academic contexts. The lessons we will present in the next section are drawn from the connected experiences of these three projects. Therefore, we do not explicitly recognise one sole action that made us come to each conclusion, since the whole experience in its diversity was the cornerstone for the following reflections.

Lessons Learned

Co-creating Knowledge with Organised Social Movements

The first lesson we want to share relates to our forms of commitment to the perspective of Indigenous communities as active subjects of the projects. Here we want to highlight the benefits we recognised of building knowledge specifically in relation to organised Indigenous movements in intense bloom and motion. Both on the ground experiences were constructed in straightforward relation to the Indigenous peoples' organised social movements for territorial and cultural recognition. By engaging with them directly, we understood that their contemporary experiences are fundamentally based on their ancestors' history of fighting back more than 500 years of oppression and colonialities as mentioned above. This qualifies the discourse and thus builds specific points of view and research questions, creating a fertile ground for knowledge co-production with committed artists and researchers.

The specific Indigenous persons we related to already had practices in interviews, mobilisations and in spreading the word about their struggles, which made possible a deepening of thought and gave density to the results. In addition, since they engage in several forums of debate on Indigenous and non-Indigenous movements, they have an outstanding overall perspective of their role in transformations to sustainability and were able to elaborate that in comprehensive ways. To go against networks of power, it might be beneficial to build alternative and diverse networks, and therefore make strong alliances as part of knowledge production (Temper et al., 2018). The Indigenous movements of the Brazilian Northeast form an already vibrant and heterogeneous network that could both gain from and present lessons to social sciences through more connections, but also tensions, to academia and research.

Nevertheless, as social scientists bound by the explicit constraints of academic practice, this choice had to be grounded in the decolonial epistemological turn, which understands such processes not as 'biased' but as 'committed'. This required us to move away from any mode of knowledge production even remotely associated with the subject-object divide and the aspiration to "pure objectivity, though this does not imply a lack of coherence.

We follow the Brazilian cartographers in their commitment to a radically relational approach that focuses not on static objects but on relations among relations (Passos et al., 2010; Lemos, 2013), as well as on the imperative to make processes of self-representation central to knowledge production (Ribeiro and Silva, 2011). Accordingly, in both projects, we did not seek to represent objects through predefined categories; rather, we aimed to produce cartographical aesthetics of life, moving away from a distant, top-down

observational stance.

This necessarily meant acknowledging that we are neither the owners nor the translators of an absolute truth about the Tupinambá or the other seven Indigenous communities involved in the second mapping project. At no point were we attempting to construct a mirror of reality, nor did we seek to decode a homogeneous perspective of a given 'people' as a unified whole.

We began from the understanding that we were working within contexts entangled in coloniality, contexts shaped by historical and multiple interactions and conflicts traversed by material relations. This perspective was incorporated into every methodological stage of the projects. For instance, in *Tupi-Alive*, we moved away from the essentialising question, 'What is it to be Tupinambá?', and instead posed a different inquiry: 'What makes a Tupinambá here and now?'

Along the cartographic routes, we identified possible relationships with the IPCs and the situations in which they were embedded, that is, through the materiality of their everyday practices, rather than from an omniscient or all-seeing perspective of what this public policy should look like or how it ought to be implemented.

In sum, our projects could not correspond to the famous metaphor proposed by Lévi-Strauss (1967), in which the researcher of 'native' cultures is likened to an astronomer tasked with discovering and producing meaning through the distant observation of far-removed cultural configurations. Instead, in acknowledging the legacies of coloniality, our activities were directly and consciously shaped by Indigenous life and struggle in the Northeast.

This broader epistemological stance enabled intense and vibrant connections with the Indigenous movement, as well as engagement with the evolving reflections on autonomy and self-recognition set in motion by Indigenous actors themselves.

Challenges of Creating Spaces for Dialogue in Environments of Coloniality

We also wish to emphasise lessons we have learned regarding participation and democratic engagement in knowledge co-production within spaces entangled in structural violence and hierarchical power. Generating spaces of dialogue is a genuine challenge. It is imperative to acknowledge the continued existence of asymmetries, even within the most well-intentioned projects.

First, we reflect on the challenges related to our decision to work with the organised Indigenous movement. For example, we neither wished nor were able to invite large cocoa farmers to the table, as doing so would have jeopardised the relationships of trust we had established with Indigenous leaders. In our view, this should not be regarded as a 'missing element' but rather as an explicit epistemological choice, one with its own benefits and limitations. In this sense, we sought to generate 'safe enough' spaces for dialogue (Pereira et al., 2020), making a deliberate effort to include the voices of Indigenous women, young

people and elders, among others. At the same time, we recognised the limits to opening spaces for speech within colonial contexts. There is no genuinely 'safe enough' table when the broader context produces situations in which a school bus is struck by gunfire along its usual route on an ordinary Wednesday morning, as occurred in Tupinambá territory in 2013.

Second, under no circumstances were our projects conceived as 'giving voice' to the subjects of Indigenous struggles in the Northeast. Such a framing would be neither desirable nor accurate, as these communities already possess strong and active voices that resonate across multiple political arenas, many beyond our own awareness. This issue is particularly sensitive in Brazil, where for more than 500 years colonial law officially deemed Indigenous people incapable of speaking for themselves: first, missionaries acted as their 'translators', and later the State imposed a 'custody' regime, granting Indigenous peoples a legal status comparable to that of minors.

To suggest that we were 'giving voice' would risk inadvertently reinforcing this historical discourse and practice. Instead, we sought to work alongside the Tupinambá and other Indigenous movements in northeastern Brazil to build bonds and connections through which multiple voices and perspectives could converge, generating new forms of understanding and, consequently, new ways of acting in the world. The resulting cartographies reflect arrangements of discourse made possible only through the situated encounters of the two projects and the reflections developed within the third. They represent one articulation of our effort to produce what we describe as a 'common ground' of knowledge creation, grounded in local perspectives that are explicitly situated, unique and non-universal.

This commitment also explains our preference for diverse forms of expression in presenting project outcomes. Videos featuring the faces and bodies of our Indigenous partners, direct quotations and analytical text authored by us appear in deliberate juxtaposition, suggesting that no clear divide structures the resulting cartography. We aimed to cultivate a polyphonic discourse, made possible only through the contingencies of the projects and the diversity of positions and viewpoints they encompassed.

Third, rather than attempting to eliminate power relations, we sought to make asymmetries an explicit part of the communicative and knowledge-building process. We learned that maintaining clarity about power relations may be more conducive to co-producing knowledge than attempting to 'empower' others or to create a supposedly 'powerless' environment, an aspiration we consider illusory. Our objective was to increase what Brazilian cartographers describe as the degree of communicability, or the 'quantum of transversality', understood as the level of openness to different visions that are distinct in quality yet equal in value (Passos et al., 2010).

The Tupivivo and Cartographic Routes projects involved working groups composed of the two of us, other academics, non-Indigenous activists and Indigenous leaders who

expressed a specific interest in participating. In both projects, Indigenous partners were involved throughout the entire process, from methodological design and formulation of research questions to the organisation and presentation of results. They participated actively as co-producers, including during periods when we were away from the villages, through emails and telephone calls.

It is also important to emphasise that more sensitive matters were discussed exclusively with Indigenous leaders, always respecting what could and could not be made public regarding Indigenous life and struggle in northeastern Brazil. In contexts where territorial disputes are ongoing, certain types of information may unintentionally jeopardise social movement strategies. For this reason, committed researchers must remain attentive and humbly aware of the potential consequences of disclosure.

Language is Key

Last, but certainly not least, we wish to address the question of language and the circulation of knowledge within co-production processes that mobilise different epistemological backgrounds. We came to realise that researchers face a crossroads when choosing the formats in which to present project outcomes. On the one hand, institutional outputs and data-driven projects can be readily mobilised by Indigenous movements when pressing State demands, yet they are also more easily co-opted. On the other hand, artistic outputs may open lines of flight from symbolic oppression, but they often have limited capacity to influence legal disputes or institutional struggles for rights.

In this sense, language is a decisive factor in the development and planning of committed research, including decisions about alternative funding mechanisms.

As stated previously, we understand our cartographies as projects situated somewhere between art, social science and activism. We draw on aesthetic resources to shape our work, engage our academic training to reflect critically on the issues at stake, and consciously rely on our political commitments as activists to guide our support for Indigenous struggles for historical reparation. By adopting an artistic perspective, we seek innovation in both discourse and media, recognising that the language of power is embedded within colonial structures that constrain expression, particularly for Indigenous and other traditional peoples.

The open character of our cartographies was therefore explicitly intended to avoid some of the potential traps associated with 'using the enemy's weapons'. After all, one might argue that relying exclusively on the structures of constituted power, or seeking only forms of representation that enable 'seeing like a State' (Scott, 1998), risks facilitating the reabsorption of such work into colonial formations.

A particularly troubling manifestation of this dynamic is the appropriation by corporations and the State of the language of 'community-based' and 'participatory'

initiatives. In this regard, we distinguish our cartographies from other participatory mapping projects in Brazil and Latin America, which are not infrequently deployed to legitimise large-scale business ventures, extractivist agendas and authoritarian development schemes. At the same time, it is important to acknowledge that significant advances in rights protection for subaltern peoples have historically emerged in connection with community-based and participatory mapping practices, particularly in Latin America (Acseirad, 2012).

One important example of participatory mapping as a counter-hegemonic tool is the 'Nova Cartografia Social da Amazônia'. This politically significant initiative, alongside similar projects across Brazil and Latin America, focuses on collectively deciding which themes and issues should be represented on maps grounded in geographical coordinates, with particular attention to cultural and symbolic disputes. Its proponents argue that although maps were historically instruments of colonial domination, they can also be repurposed to challenge power, depending on who guides the process and how it is conducted.

The 'Nova Cartografia Social da Amazônia' was a key inspiration for our own projects, especially regarding its links to territorial struggles and its emphasis on culture. Our cartographies also placed particular emphasis on counter-visualities (Mirzoeff, 2011) and confronting the coloniality of seeing (Barriendos, 2011). As noted above, the decision to produce mappings through polyphonic discourse was fundamental, as was our use of multiple media and formats, including web documentaries, posters, books and scientific articles.

We understood that participation and inter-epistemic dialogue could gain traction through transmedia practices (Jenkins, 2006). This approach resonated with the diversity of ways in which meaning is produced and disseminated through 'environmental narratives' (Robertson et al., 2000) within Indigenous villages, including alternative ways of envisioning 'nature', 'the future', 'autonomy' and 'territory'. Our aim was to contribute to ongoing processes of storytelling without reverting to epistemic frameworks that reproduce exclusion and violence.

We embraced the opportunity afforded by the projects' grounding in scientific, activist and artistic traditions, constructing what we described as a 'tripod' that enabled experimentation with new forms of language and symbolic representation.

One lesson we learned is that the openings created by this methodological 'tripod' made the results of our projects more difficult to appropriate or instrumentalise. Unlike other cartographic initiatives conducted in the same territories, our maps were never used against the Indigenous movement. Another positive outcome was the extensive symbolic appropriation of our cartographies at the local level, particularly in analogue formats such as posters and books, which remained visible across the territories years after the projects concluded.

These gains, however, were accompanied by limitations in institutional arenas. The cartographies proved less effective as tools in formal institutional disputes, as their language was not immediately adaptable to legal procedures.

Conclusion

Drawing on these experiences, we argue that a decolonial co-creation of knowledge must address challenges across at least three spheres: (1) political commitment and network building; (2) hierarchy and persistent asymmetries of power; and (3) language and visualities. These challenges, in turn, cannot be confronted without an explicitly committed and decolonial perspective that shapes both what research produces and how it is communicated.

As noted throughout, we learned that committed research must exercise particular care regarding which aspects of a given life or struggle are made visible in its outputs, so as to minimise the risks of appropriation and co-option. We believe that sharing reflections emerging from the Global South, especially those developed at the intersections of applied social sciences and counter-hegemonic understandings of nature, territory and traditional cultures, can generate important insights into processes of knowledge co-production.

We therefore advocate for closer proximity between research and movements that are actively generating alternative forms of life on Earth and making deliberate efforts to disseminate these initiatives. Close engagement with material struggles produces new ways of understanding and relating to the world, ways that are fundamental to imagining and enacting more sustainable futures.

Once again, we follow Lugones (2018), who reminds us that tensions and direct embodied engagement with movement networks and their distinct ways of seeing and being in the world enable a profound rejection of hierarchical dichotomies and categorical fragmentations that structure colonial worldviews and formations of coloniality. Connection with knowledge generated through political action and the (re)diversification of natural and cultural landscapes is therefore of immense value for researchers committed to contributing to sustainability transformations.

Further research and projects developed at the frontiers of art and politics could advance this task. We hope that the initiatives discussed here may inspire open and experimental projects oriented along two vectors: engaging in implementation efforts beyond the ivory tower of academia, and bringing alternative forms of research and practice into the university, as many transdisciplinary scholars seek to do.

Unfortunately, the current political climate in Brazil, and elsewhere, marked by the rise of authoritarian right-wing regimes, offers limited space for such experimentation. The calls and public policies referenced in this chapter are no longer available, and the few

remaining spaces for transformation are being systematically constrained. Territorial struggles and the research practices connected to them are increasingly harassed by neoliberal and authoritarian modes of governance, hyper-specialisation, and instrumental uses aligned with corporate interests.

Nonetheless, our cartographies, as part of a broader movement for cultural affirmation and self-determination among Indigenous populations in Latin America, illuminate another logic of transdisciplinarity, one in which value resides primarily in the relationships, and indeed the tensions, between academia, social movements and political mobilisation. This logic has the potential to fertilise and diversify research and policy pathways, fostering more democratic and ethical approaches.

In this context, it becomes even more urgent to systematise the contributions of committed research and decolonial methodological practices developed in Brazil in recent decades, and to reflect on how the lessons learned from those experiences might be reactivated. Such efforts may deepen connections with Indigenous and other social movements in Brazil that continue to generate vital lessons despite the adversities of the present moment.

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Chapter 4

Women's Land Rights in Africa: Collectivisation vs. Privatisation-based Solutions

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Abstract

Although rural African women are disproportionately responsible for agricultural labour, they often lack legal rights to own and inherit land. Many externally imposed solutions to these struggles, advanced by large non-governmental organisations (NGOs), operate within a neoliberal, rights-based framework that assumes land must be privatised before women can be granted equal ownership rights. Within this paradigm, the women's land rights movement, supported by the United Nations (UN), has advocated for legal reforms to strengthen women's property rights. However, critics argue that this movement has simultaneously bolstered private ownership laws while eroding communal land systems known as "the commons," where communities collectively access and manage land and resources. In contrast, grassroots movements resisting land privatisation have gained momentum across Africa. These movements are largely led by women, for whom the collectivisation of land offers a pathway to land security rooted in shared use rather than individual ownership. Through both formal and informal organising, these women are reclaiming land and transforming it into a productive agricultural resource. This chapter presents a critical review of literature comparing grassroots collectivist approaches and privatisation-based solutions to advancing gender equity in African land ownership. Particular attention is given to the types of knowledge produced through diverse research methodologies. The chapter also highlights the distinctive contributions of qualitative and quantitative approaches in supporting African women's advocacy for land rights and discusses the implications of these methodologies for decolonising policy and practice.

Keywords: rural women · land rights · neoliberalism · grassroots movements · collectivisation · privatisation · decolonising

Background

For millions of rural Africans, land is the primary resource sustaining their livelihoods and subsistence. Within this context, women carry out the majority of agricultural labour, estimated between 60% and 80% (Kaloustian and Alhassan, 2010). Yet, in many African countries, women lack formal legal rights to own land. Their access to and control over land is often dependent on relationships with male relatives, fathers, husbands, sons, or brothers. This gendered exclusion from property rights significantly contributes to the higher levels of poverty and food insecurity experienced by women compared to men (Kaloustian and Alhassan, 2010). For example, when widowed, women frequently risk losing the land they have cultivated, thereby undermining their long-term economic and food security, as well as that of their dependents (Alhassan, 2010).

In response, efforts to secure women's land rights have spurred legal and policy initiatives aimed at increasing women's access to land and addressing broader issues of poverty and inequality (Razavi, 2003). Across African contexts, land ownership largely operates under informal customary or traditional tenure systems (Wily, 2006). These customary arrangements coexist with formal legal systems introduced during the colonial era. Rather than constituting a rigid framework, customary tenure is best understood as a fluid set of local practices and norms, flexible, dynamic, and responsive to evolving socio-political conditions (Wily, 2006). Under these systems, women's access to land is shaped by local histories, legal structures, and social norms, which vary according to whether communities are matrilineal or patrilineal, and according to the specific legacies of colonial rule (Paradza et al., 2020).

Formal interventions aimed at improving women's land access have generally operated within a neoliberal, rights-based framework. This paradigm assumes that land must first be privatised and individual ownership secured through titling and registration to ensure gender equity. While these strategies have been promoted as gender-equalising, they have also exposed land held under customary tenure to commercial pressures, including acquisition by foreign investors. The World Bank has framed such reforms as "community-based" (Federici, 2012), yet it remains crucial to critically assess whether these interventions have tangibly improved African women's lived experiences, particularly in terms of economic empowerment and social security.

Methodology

This chapter undertakes a critical review of the historical context of land ownership and use in Africa, alongside empirical research examining the effectiveness of land titling and registration in protecting African women's land rights. The analysis is grounded in two key theoretical frameworks. First, the concept of *the commons*, as elaborated below, is used to interrogate the impact and significance of privatisation regimes. Second, *decolonial epistemologies* inform the evaluation of empirical research, particularly in relation to African women's sovereignty and self-determination. Together, these frameworks guide the chapter's examination of research findings and their implications for theory, academic inquiry, and policy.

Customary Tenure as an Instance of "the Commons"

Customary tenure often embodies what is known as *the commons*, a mode of land ownership and resource management based on collective stewardship rather than state or private control. The commons refers broadly to resources that are collectively owned, managed, and utilised by a community (Hess, 2008). This concept also encompasses the practice of *commoning*, which describes the social processes and movements that create, maintain, and defend shared ownership of material and immaterial resources, ranging from land and housing to creative assets like copyright (Hess, 2008).

Federici and Caffentzis (2014) emphasise that commoning is "the principle by which human beings have organised their existence for thousands of years" (p. 93). Thus, the commons should not be viewed merely as localised experiments in communal living but as a historically pervasive and socially embedded mode of organisation. Africa remains one of the few regions where communal tenure of land, property, and agricultural production continues to thrive, despite ongoing pressures from global capital to dismantle it (Alden Wily, 2001).

The commons can be contrasted against both the public, which refers to land and resources owned by the state, and against the private, which connotes ownership by one or several individuals. The idea of the commons as a space outside of the public/private divide makes it particularly relevant to women, whose relegation to reproductive labour, such as food preparation, procreation, child-rearing, and, in Africa, agricultural production, isolates them within the private sphere, making collective political organising more difficult.

In this context, the commons presents a potential means of resisting such isolation. Federici (2012) argues that the commons enable women to "overcome the isolation in which reproductive activities are performed and the separation between the private and the public spheres that has contributed so much to hiding and rationalising women's exploitation in the family and the home" (p. 4). For African women, then, the commons

represent not only a material resource but also a space of social and political possibility.

The conceptual framework of the commons serves as a compelling alternative to both the universalist, rights-based legal reforms imposed from above and the cultural relativist arguments that reject external efforts to improve women's land access. By centring collective ownership and community-based stewardship, this framework offers new insights into how land rights can be advanced in ways that align with both local realities and gender equity.

Decolonisation and Neocolonialism

Decolonisation constitutes the second core theoretical framework informing this analysis. Decolonising methodologies seek to de-centre Western epistemologies and re-centre the lived experiences, knowledge systems, and worldviews of Indigenous peoples. This shift applies not only to the questions researchers ask but also to the types of data collected and the interpretive lenses applied to that data. In this sense, decolonisation challenges dominant narratives and values imposed by colonial systems of knowledge production.

More literally, decolonising research methodologies position imperial domination and its enduring legacy as a central interpretive context. Such methodologies aim to expose, critique, and ultimately dismantle the historical power structures that underpin colonialism, economic exploitation, and cultural erasure. They call attention to how research practices have served as tools of domination, and instead emphasise approaches that are grounded in respect, reciprocity, and relevance to the communities involved.

A crucial dimension of this framework is the acknowledgement of neocolonialism, the continued exercise of colonial control through indirect, often economic or political, means (Nkrumah, 1965). Neocolonialism operates through mechanisms such as international development agendas, global market forces, and donor-driven policy reforms that can override local autonomy, including in areas like land governance and women's rights.

Decolonial methodologies, therefore, do more than historicise dispossession and injustice; they actively advocate for institutional and systemic transformation within current economic and socio-political realities (McGregor, 2018). Central to these approaches is the principle of self-determination, the right of Indigenous and marginalised peoples to define, lead, and benefit from the research and policies that affect their lives. In the context of African women's land rights, this entails resisting externally imposed, top-down solutions in favour of approaches that are contextually grounded, community-led, and justice-oriented.

Political and Economic Context: Privatisation and Land Grabbing

Throughout the twentieth century, efforts to privatise land ownership in Africa have had detrimental impacts on women's rights to control, access, and own land. In many African socio-political contexts, the issue of agricultural land privatisation is deeply intertwined with the well-being and political agency of women, who continue to perform the majority of agricultural labour. Any discussion of women's land rights must therefore consider the broader international economic forces shaping land governance and access in rural African communities.

Historically, privatisation initiatives in Africa were modelled on European systems of land ownership. These efforts sought to survey, register, and assign legal ownership of land to individual title holders, overwhelmingly men. For instance, Kenya's Plan to Intensify the Development of African Agriculture, which operated from the 1950s to the 1990s, converted land held under customary tenure into individually titled property, almost exclusively under the names of male relatives (Nyamu-Musembi, 2008). While this plan aimed to modernise agricultural production, it simultaneously undermined women's traditional land rights and contributed to increased landlessness and social stratification by concentrating land ownership in the hands of a few.

The privatisation and titling of African land were also embedded within broader economic reforms promoted by the World Bank throughout the 1980s. In 1975, the World Bank's Land Policy Division issued a statement proposing land titling as a prerequisite for development. Influenced by thinkers like Hernando de Soto, who famously argued that privatisation transforms land from "dead capital" into "live capital" by enabling its use as collateral, these reforms emphasised the formalisation of property rights. Under the framework of Structural Adjustment Programmes (SAPs), many African governments were offered loans in exchange for implementing specific trade and policy conditions, including legal reforms that facilitated land commercialisation and privatisation (Englert and Daley, 2008).

These SAPs also required African states to adopt export-oriented economic policies, often at the expense of small-scale agriculture. This shift undermined the food security of rural households, particularly for women who depended on subsistence farming to feed their families. The emphasis on large-scale commercial agriculture reduced support for local food systems, thereby weakening women's traditional roles in food production and exacerbating gendered economic disparities.

registration have facilitated a wave of large-scale land acquisitions, often referred to as land grabbing. This trend was accelerated by the 2007–2008 global food and financial crises, which led transnational corporations and foreign governments to seek secure access to fertile land, water, and food production in the Global South (GRAIN et al., 2014). In more recent years, international financial institutions and global investors have continued to prioritise the privatisation and commercialisation of land across Africa. Over

the past 15 years, policies promoting land privatisation and displacing rural communities.

Land grabbing involves the acquisition through lease or purchase of vast tracts of land in low-income countries, typically without adequate compensation for or consent from local communities. These deals displace rural populations, convert communal lands into industrial-scale agricultural or biofuel production zones, and contribute to the degradation of local ecosystems. In many cases, land sales involve tens of thousands, or even hundreds of thousands, of hectares in a single transaction (GRAIN, 2008). Investors acquire land not to benefit host communities, but to grow export crops, secure water resources, or produce biofuels for consumption in wealthy countries. These developments have intensified land insecurity for rural women, whose customary land rights are often unrecognised by formal legal systems and thus vulnerable to expropriation.

The concept of land grabbing encompasses both historical colonisation and its modern counterpart, neocolonialism. Contemporary international development policies, particularly those involving loan financing and trade, are largely shaped by global financial institutions such as the World Bank and the International Monetary Fund (IMF). These institutions operate under a weighted voting system, where decision-making power is concentrated among the largest financial contributors, typically from the Global North. As such, these institutions often function as neocolonial actors, exerting significant influence over African legal systems and social policies to advance external economic and political interests.

This power imbalance sustains profound global inequalities. According to the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP), approximately \$500 billion in trade flows annually from the Global South to the Global North, while only a fraction of that, around \$50 billion, returns in the form of conditional aid (Sharma, 2009, p. 43). Such statistics starkly illustrate the exploitative dynamics embedded in global economic structures.

Privatisation policies have had devastating consequences for local communities. Entire villages have been forcibly evicted from their land, without fair compensation or the free, prior, and informed consent of affected populations. While companies acquiring land may promise employment opportunities, these rarely materialise. In many cases, firms import precarious, underpaid migrant labourers instead of hiring local residents. Older farmers are frequently excluded from new jobs and forced into dependency on younger family members for survival.

When land is converted for industrial farming, labour conditions are commonly unregulated, creating a vulnerable workforce lacking health protections, job security, or legal recourse. Wages are typically meagre, barely sustaining workers and their families (Land Research Action Network, 2011). Field studies further show that employment generated by large-scale agribusiness ventures rarely compensates for the ecological and economic losses resulting from the destruction of forests, farms, and wetlands (Schott, 2010).

In many countries, laws require community consultation prior to land acquisition. However, such consultations are often conducted with absentee landlords, former colonial landholders, or politically connected elites, rather than the communities whose land and livelihoods are at stake (Fonjong et al., 2015; Ndi, 2017; Ndi and Batterbury, 2017). These intermediaries often claim to represent local interests while primarily serving their own.

The consequences of land grabs for women have been particularly severe. Although a small minority of women may benefit from employment or income-generating opportunities provided by land investors, the majority are negatively impacted. Women are disproportionately evicted and displaced, and they bear the brunt of the environmental degradation that follows land conversion (Fonjong, 2017). Those living and working on privatised land often lose access to vital natural resources such as water, firewood, and grazing areas. Women also tend to receive inadequate or no compensation when displaced, deepening existing gender inequalities in land access and economic security.

Despite these realities, land grabs have been promoted through a "win-win" discourse, particularly by the World Bank. This narrative portrays land deals as mutually beneficial: investors profit while local communities supposedly gain jobs, infrastructure, and modern agricultural technologies. Such discourse legitimises foreign land acquisition and is encapsulated in documents like the *Principles for Responsible Agricultural Investment* (Chu, 2011), which aim not to stop land grabs, but to regulate and normalise them as an inevitable phase of agricultural development.

A growing awareness of the adverse effects of privatisation, displacement, and deepening rural poverty has prompted a policy shift. Recent reforms, particularly those initiated by the World Bank, now promote the integration of customary tenure into titling frameworks. These so-called "pro-poor" policies involve the formal registration of communal lands, often through group titles managed by local representative councils.

At first glance, this appears to be a move toward protecting traditional land rights. However, in practice, these reforms frequently repackage privatisation. Communal titles are often administered by male-dominated associations that replicate patriarchal norms, offering women little to no meaningful participation in land governance. As a result, women face a lose-lose scenario, where neither privatisation nor community-based titling sufficiently protects their interests.

Moreover, the underlying economic logic remains unchanged. In its 2009 report, *Awakening Africa's Sleeping Giant: Prospects for Commercial Agriculture in the Guinea Savannah Zone and Beyond*, the World Bank describes Africa as an underperforming agricultural frontier. It labels the Guinea Savannah as "one of the largest underused agricultural land reserves in the world." The term *underused*, however, does not imply *unused*. Rather, it reflects an economic worldview in which land is considered valuable

only when appropriated and exploited for commercial profit.

From this perspective, even the embrace of customary tenure appears less a recognition of Indigenous land rights and more a strategic workaround to facilitate continued access to African land and resources, under the guise of local participation and poverty reduction.

Political Strategies to Promote and Protect Land Rights

Land titling has often been promoted as a necessary strategy to safeguard communities against both land grabbing and gender inequality. Proponents argue that formalising land rights through titling enhances legal recognition and security of tenure, especially for vulnerable groups. However, this approach is contested by critics who argue that land titling itself can facilitate privatisation and dispossession. They highlight that, in practice, titling may serve as a gateway to land commodification and investor-friendly land policies that disproportionately harm marginalised populations.

One of the key criticisms is that community land titles often fail to ensure meaningful representation or long-term security for the communities they aim to protect. In many cases, the individuals appointed to manage community land, typically male elites, have the authority to sell or lease land to foreign investors without the free, prior, and informed consent of the community they represent (Federici, 2012). Furthermore, titling does not guarantee protection from state expropriation. In numerous contexts, land legally titled to individuals or groups can be reclassified as serving a "public utility" and subsequently expropriated if deemed necessary for national development priorities (Ullenberg, 2009).

When compensation is provided in such cases, it is often issued solely to the male head of household, reinforcing patriarchal norms and excluding women from financial redress (Widman, 2014). These practices deepen existing inequalities and leave the poorest and most politically marginalised, especially rural women, vulnerable to further dispossession.

The claim that land titling is essential to protect customary tenure stands in direct contradiction to arguments that titling acts as a precursor to harmful land grabs. In this contested landscape, empirical research plays a crucial role in disentangling competing claims and clarifying which land governance policies support, and which undermine, the rights of rural communities and women.

It is important to recognise, however, that not all research is created equal. Studies vary widely in the methods they use to collect and analyse data, in how they frame their findings, and in what information they choose to prioritise or omit. Definitions of what constitutes valid "data" also differ: qualitative research centres the lived experiences and narratives of individuals, often through interviews, focus groups, or ethnography, while quantitative research relies on numerical data and statistical analysis to identify patterns, trends, or disparities across populations and time.

The following section presents a brief review of research on the gendered impacts of land titling and registration across Africa, with particular attention to methodological diversity. This review highlights the contributions of both qualitative and quantitative approaches to understanding how land policies affect women's rights, autonomy, and well-being, and identifies promising strategies for policy interventions that promote genuine gender equity in land governance.

Findings from Quantitative and Mixed-Methods Research

Several studies have explored the impact of land titling on gender equality using quantitative and mixed-methods approaches. These studies offer important insights, though their findings often reveal limitations in both methodology and real-world application.

Campus (2016), for instance, examines the effect of land titling on gender equality in joint-headed rural households in Nepal, using data from the 2011 Demographic and Health Survey. Focusing on households engaged in agricultural production, the study finds that women listed on land titles exhibit higher levels of empowerment, measured by decision-making authority within the household, compared to women not included on titles. However, these findings must be interpreted with caution. First, the analysis does not control for confounding variables such as education, income, or social class, which may influence both empowerment and inclusion on land titles. Second, the study demonstrates correlation but not causation; it is equally plausible that empowered women are more likely to advocate for their inclusion on land titles, rather than empowerment resulting from the titling itself. Therefore, the study does not offer conclusive evidence that land titling directly contributes to women's empowerment.

Some mixed-methods studies also suggest that titling can act as a deterrent to land grabbing. In Tigray, Ethiopia, Gebre-Egziabher (2013) compared regions with varying levels of land titling and found that areas with higher rates of titled land experienced fewer instances of land grabbing. Conversely, land grabs were more frequent in regions where titling was limited. While these findings are suggestive, they too suffer from limitations in establishing causality. For example, areas with higher literacy levels and greater access to legal infrastructure, conditions that may coincide with higher titling rates, might also be less attractive to land grabbers due to increased resistance. The study also claims that titling improves gender equity, referencing constitutional provisions that address women's rights to land. However, it does not offer empirical evidence linking these legal provisions to improvements in women's lived experiences.

A more detailed examination comes from Widman (2014), who investigates land tenure reform in Madagascar, focusing on the rural municipality of Soavinandriana. The reform promoted formal land titling, and Widman's research found that factors commonly associated with women's empowerment, such as education, smaller household size, and

employment outside of agriculture, were positively correlated with land registered in a woman's name. The programme supported individual land claims for both men and women. However, Widman's analysis suggests that pre-existing empowerment enabled women to pursue titling, rather than titling leading to empowerment.

Moreover, household land titles were predominantly registered under the husband's name. In some cases, women believed they were included in the title, only to later discover they were not. Focus group discussions revealed that many women chose not to request joint titles, fearing it would be perceived as challenging their husbands' authority. These findings underscore how cultural and interpersonal dynamics can limit the effectiveness of legal reforms in promoting gender equity.

Women in Widman's study cited the desire to protect land from grabbing as a key motivation for pursuing registration. However, the cost of registration emerged as the primary barrier. Among those who had not registered their land, 69% of women and 71% of men reported that financial constraints prevented them from doing so. These figures suggest that the land registration system failed to support either women in jointly headed households or the poorest members of the community, those most vulnerable to land insecurity.

Significantly, Widman notes that recent land reforms in Madagascar provide theoretical protection against land grabbing even for unregistered land. Yet fewer than one-third of the country's regions had established a Local Land Office, the institutions responsible for titling and public education on land rights. Additionally, communal lands, such as forests and grazing areas, are generally not eligible for registration, leaving them especially susceptible to external appropriation. These findings highlight the shortcomings of titling regimes in protecting the land rights of rural populations, particularly poor and marginalised women, and underscore the importance of community education and legal literacy to ensure meaningful participation and understanding in land governance.

Findings from Qualitative Research, Case Studies, and Cross-Country Comparisons

Qualitative research, case studies, and cross-country comparisons offer crucial insights into the gendered impacts of land titling and land grabbing. These studies foreground lived experiences, illuminating how structural changes in land governance disproportionately affect women, particularly in rural African contexts.

Otieno (2019) examines the effects of land titling and expropriation in Kenya's Kadenge community, specifically focusing on the adjudication and subsequent sale of the Yala Swamp to Dominion Farms Ltd. Women in the community had traditionally relied on the swamp for fishing, agriculture, water, and the harvesting of papyrus reeds used in shelter construction and basket weaving. Despite legal requirements for community consultation in land transactions, the majority of the women reported that they were not consulted. Instead, consultations primarily involved male political elites who failed to account for the

women's dependence on the land. Based on this case, the author recommends several strategies to protect women's land rights, including expanding land rights education for women, strengthening women's capacity to assert their rights, creating legal protections for communally used land, and mandating that all land users, not just formal representatives, must be included in consultation processes. The study also proposes instituting gendered quorum requirements to ensure women's meaningful inclusion in community consultations.

Gmur (2019) provides another case study from Tanzania's Kilolo District in the Iringa region, where land grabbing disproportionately impacted women. The study highlights how land grabs often target the commons, lands used collectively by communities and typically ineligible for individual titling. Such practices restrict women's access to communal land, deepen their dependence on male landowners, and further entrench gendered inequalities. As in other studies, Gmur observed that decisions to sell land were often made by male political representatives or family members without input from the women who used the land daily.

Marfurt (2019) presents a case study of a large-scale bioenergy project in Sierra Leone, illustrating how the formalisation of customary land rights through titling can marginalise women. The project resulted in the privatisation and commodification of land, concentrating ownership in the hands of male elites. Rather than empowering women, titling and land registration led to their exclusion and the erosion of livelihoods previously supported by access to communal lands. The study concludes that privatisation processes exacerbate gender disparities, particularly when land is absorbed into large-scale agribusiness ventures.

A comparative study by ElHadary and Obeng-Odoom (2012) examines land tenure systems in Ghana and Sudan. Despite distinct differences in customary practices, the study finds that in both contexts, landowners are vulnerable to eviction and dispossession by the state, traditional authorities, or corporations. The authors argue that land grabbing is not merely the result of weak governance, inadequate legal protections, or lack of customary tenure recognition. Rather, it is actively facilitated by alliances between transnational corporations and both state and traditional authorities. These actors use land commodification and individualisation, enabled by titling, compulsory acquisition, and land registration, to dispossess local communities. Importantly, this commodification process disproportionately excludes women.

Benjaminsen et al. (2009) compare land rights formalisation in Mali, Niger, and South Africa, identifying significant barriers and unintended consequences across all three countries. In Mali, the land registration process requires fluency in French and financial resources equivalent to approximately US\$3,000, requirements that effectively exclude the majority of rural farmers, especially women. In many instances, descendants of colonial settlers or elites were able to register land in their own names and then sell it for profit. In Niger, titling reforms provoked internal conflicts as community members vied

for formal recognition as landowners, where land had previously been held in shared use. In such contexts, men disproportionately benefited from titling, gaining privileged access and legal claims while women were often excluded from the formal process altogether.

Case Studies of Resistance

Research on the impacts of privatisation and land titling on women has increasingly focused on grassroots resistance to land commodification and land grabs. These case studies reveal that women across Africa are not passive recipients of land dispossession, but rather active agents challenging state and corporate encroachment on their land and livelihoods.

In Uganda's Amuru District, women led large-scale protests in 2011 against the appropriation of community land for a sugar plantation. Their protests targeted both the plantation company and local government officials. The women demanded an immediate halt to the surveying and delimitation of land, invoking their long-standing generational use of the land. Their resistance implicitly linked land mapping and titling processes to the broader erosion of women's livelihoods (Martiniello, 2017).

In Zimbabwe, *La Via Campesina*, a transnational agrarian rights movement with local chapters, has taken a firm stance against land titling, even when such titles are issued in women's names. The organisation views titling as a mechanism that legitimises land privatisation without delivering meaningful benefits for women's well-being or autonomy (Collins, 2019).

A compelling ethnographic case is presented by Eddouada (2021), who examines the *Sulaliyat* movement in Morocco. *Sulaliyat* refers to a new cadre of women leaders emerging from rural and semi-urban areas to resist land expropriation and forced displacement. Rather than framing their claims through human rights or constitutional language, the *Sulaliyat* appeal directly to the spiritual role of the King, tapping into local cultural frameworks and bypassing Western legal discourses. The movement explicitly rejects land commercialisation and privatisation, instead framing land as a "jewel", a sacred trust to be protected and passed on to future generations.

In South Africa, the umbrella organisation *The Feminist Table* serves as a platform for women-led grassroots groups opposing extractive land development projects. One such group is composed of women from Xolobeni village, who mobilised against titanium mining. Another is based in Somkhele, where women organised resistance against coal mining due to its adverse environmental and health effects. These member groups adopt an eco-feminist lens, recognising women as the "shock absorbers" of Africa's climate and land crises, bearing the brunt of pollution, food insecurity, and environmental degradation (Fakier and Cock, 2018).

Some grassroots efforts have successfully disrupted harmful corporate activity. In Steel Valley, South Africa, women organised against a local steel mill that had polluted groundwater with toxic waste. The environmental contamination resulted in birth defects, cancer, crop failure, and livestock deaths. This community-led resistance ultimately pressured the mill to shut down (Cock, 2007).

Other land movements have embraced more radical strategies, including the reappropriation of private land through squatting. The *Landless People's Movement* (LPM) in South Africa, comprising largely of women and youth, has called for land redistribution and the occupation of unused or unjustly appropriated land. The LPM was born from a community's resistance to forced evictions in Protea South, illustrating how informal land reclamation can become a form of political defiance and survival (Sinwell, 2015).

Beyond rural contexts, Silvia Rivera (2013) draws attention to urban farming as a powerful act of resistance by displaced women farmers. As women are pushed into urban peripheries by land grabs, many have appropriated vacant plots and public spaces, including roadsides, railways, parks, and university grounds, for agricultural use. These women cultivate crops, graze livestock, and sell produce, without formal permission or payment. Rivera describes this activity as a process of re-communalisation, wherein public and private urban spaces are reclaimed and transformed into new commons that sustain marginalised women and their families.

Theoretical and Research Implications

In line with Bassa et al. (2014), the findings presented here underscore the critical role of qualitative research and case studies in capturing the nuanced and gendered impacts of land tenure policies on women's empowerment and economic security. While quantitative research has the potential to contribute valuable insights into women's land use and the consequences of privatisation and titling, it must be conducted with methodological rigor. This includes careful consideration of causal directionality and the identification and control of potential confounding variables.

Notably, the quantitative literature often presents a more optimistic view of land privatisation and titling than qualitative studies and case research. This discrepancy may stem from research questions in some quantitative studies being insufficiently informed by the lived experiences of rural African women. However, when quantitative research is grounded in these experiences, as exemplified by Widman's (2014) study, it can yield meaningful insights. Widman found that land titling was accessible primarily to women with economic and social privileges and that titling frequently reinforced gendered inequality within households. This research demonstrates how embedding lived experience in the research design enables a more accurate assessment of policy outcomes.

Integrating qualitative findings into the conceptual framework of quantitative studies is essential to provide a deeper understanding of the motivations, constraints, and agency of women navigating land titling regimes. When adequately contextualised, quantitative approaches can clarify how land titling policies function in practice and where they diverge from their intended objectives.

Qualitative methods, such as interviews, focus groups, and case studies, are uniquely positioned to illuminate discrepancies between the theoretical protections land titling promises and the realities women face. For instance, Otieno (2019) found that the consultation processes mandated prior to land sales often exclude women, despite their reliance on communal land for subsistence and income. Similarly, Gmur (2019) and Benjaminsen et al. (2009) highlighted cases where male relatives or community elites made unilateral decisions to sell land, sidelining women who had no formal role in consultation or consent. Benjaminsen's study also revealed that the financial cost of titling, amounting to thousands of U.S. dollars in some regions, effectively excludes many rural poor, particularly women, from securing legal land ownership. These findings call attention to the gap between legal entitlements and actual practice, reinforcing the need for grounded research that interrogates how land rights are enacted, or denied, in everyday life.

Furthermore, qualitative research has shed light on the gendered implications of privatising the commons. Given women's disproportionate role in agricultural labour, the loss of communally-held land has uniquely adverse effects on their livelihoods. Otieno (2019) documented how women in Kenya's Kadenge community, who relied on the Yala Swamp for farming, fishing, and craft materials, were excluded from consultation on the land's sale. Similarly, Marfurt (2019) found that land titling in Sierra Leone facilitated the loss of shared resources, disproportionately disempowering women. Gmur (2019) observed that in Tanzania, communal lands cannot be titled, making them especially vulnerable to land grabs. These findings raise urgent questions about the legal status and protection of communal land, which remains a cornerstone of survival for many rural women.

Finally, the literature suggests that future research on land titling and gender equity must place greater emphasis on documenting women's resistance movements. Much grassroots activism, particularly that which occurs outside formal institutions or recognised civil society structures, remains underrepresented in scholarly discourse. Like qualitative research, case studies of resistance offer rich insight into how women themselves conceptualise and contest land privatisation. These movements often reveal alternative frameworks of land ownership rooted in communal ties, generational stewardship, and cultural belonging.

Studies by Martiniello (2017), Collins (2019), Eddouada (2021), and Cock (2007) illustrate that rural women are not merely subjects of policy but articulate powerful critiques of land titling and privatisation processes. They highlight how mapping, titling, and legal

documentation can function as instruments of dispossession rather than empowerment. Recognising these grassroots narratives as valid epistemologies, not merely anecdotes, can help reframe land governance debates in ways that centre women's voices and challenge top-down, neoliberal frameworks.

Policy Implications

Within the process of private land titling, research highlights that obtaining a title is inaccessible to many women. Factors associated with lower access to titling include interfamilial social dynamics (Campus, 2016), lower levels of education (Widman, 2014), and economic status (Widman, 2014; Benjaminsen et al., 2019). A straightforward policy adaptation that would improve accessibility is the elimination of fees associated with the process. A titling system with an entry cost of USD 3,000 is fundamentally exclusionary and of no benefit to precarious women in any setting.

In consultations for the purchase of communally held land, several studies identify a persistent problem: women are routinely excluded from such consultations, even when they are the primary users and dependents of the land being sold (Otieno, 2019; Gmur, 2019). This exclusion could be addressed through multiple policy avenues. Women should be educated and empowered regarding their legal rights to consultation and land use. Legal provisions could require that a specific proportion of women be present during land consultations. Additionally, all individuals who actively use the land should be included in consultation processes, rather than only their representatives or male family members.

Furthermore, some countries have no policies protecting communal land. Widman notes that in Madagascar, communally-held land is not open to titling processes, making it automatically at risk of external purchase.

In some countries, policies do not offer any protection for communal land. For instance, Widman notes that in Madagascar, communally held land is not eligible for titling, leaving it particularly vulnerable to external acquisition. Even where communal rights are formally recognised, customary tenure is often superseded by the decisions of state authorities, traditional leaders, or corporate actors (ElHadary and Obeng-Odoom, 2012). Moreover, these structures frequently replicate the gender inequalities inherent in customary systems, in which women have been systematically excluded from land ownership and decision-making (Whitehead and Tsikata, 2003). It is therefore evident that integrating customary tenure into privatisation-based frameworks does not necessarily provide greater security for women or for rural communities. Policies that recognise the rights of those who occupy and use land, without requiring registration or titling as a precondition, are better positioned to support women's land and economic security.

The assumption that titling and registration can secure gender equity through legal reform and enforcement must therefore be critically examined, particularly when these

very mechanisms have facilitated the dispossession of rural African women across diverse political contexts. Indeed, there is growing concern that land rights reform movements largely serve the interests of a relatively small group of educated, urban, middle-class women, who are positioned to benefit from titling systems. For the vast majority of rural women, these systems often result in the erosion of commons and heightened insecurity. Strengthening private ownership through titling appears increasingly counterproductive to the broader goal of achieving gender equity.

Zamchiya and Gausi (2015), writing on land rights and land grabbing in Malawi, offer several policy recommendations that may be applicable across contexts. They call for a moratorium on land grabbing by prohibiting large-scale land acquisitions and advocate that international funding bodies, such as the European Union and the African Development Bank, support only those projects that demonstrably preserve land-use rights for individuals already occupying or cultivating the land. They also emphasise the central role of grassroots resistance movements in protecting land rights, especially in settings where legal recourse is inaccessible to the rural poor.

Similarly, El-Hadary and Obeng-Odoom (2012) argue that land dispossession does not stem from weak governance or inadequate legal recognition of customary tenure, but rather from intentional collaboration between transnational corporations and local or international state actors. Their conclusions underscore the need for stronger policy measures that prevent land acquisition by external bodies and protect the autonomy of rural communities.

Finally, Manji (2006) critiques the contemporary focus on legal land tenure reform, arguing that it has diverted attention from earlier post-independence demands for land redistribution, from colonial landowners and their beneficiaries back to local communities. She suggests that women should not direct their energy solely toward securing legal rights, especially when those rights are inconsistently enforced and prone to erosion. Instead, the focus should be on the actual acquisition and control of land by women. This could take the form of supporting grassroots resistance movements, advocating for restitution of land taken during colonisation, and aligning with broader Indigenous movements, such as the Land Back movement in Canada, which emphasises Indigenous women's leadership and jurisdiction over land (Yellowhead Institute, 2019).

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Chapter 5

Exploring Decolonial Methodologies and (Re)framing the Questions in Urban Planning Research: Who? How? What? When?

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Abstract

Urban planning has historically served colonial and imperialist agendas, reinforcing ideas and practices that uphold a modern/colonial construct of development. Exploring decolonial methodologies, therefore, requires a process of unlearning and unsettling ingrained, taught assumptions. While postcolonial planning scholarship has opened critical debates on knowledge production in the field, we argue that it can be further enriched by engaging with decolonial theory and praxis. In particular, colonial categories of gender, race, and class must be understood through the histories of oppression and resistance rooted in specific local and regional contexts. Drawing on our own positionalities as researchers from the Global South working in Northern universities, and informed by a literature review on decolonial methodologies, we propose two sets of reflections for advancing the book's exploration of decolonial methodological learning, its theory, practice, and politics. First, we examine research questions through the lens of who conducts research and how it is done. Second, we explore how decolonial methodologies inform what research is pursued and when it is undertaken. Adopting a decolonial standpoint requires unpacking the often-unexamined stage of research conceptualisation that precedes methodological design, thereby embracing the research process in its entirety. This approach entails confronting the power dynamics embedded within and beyond academia, and finding new ways to challenge the hierarchies of knowledge that perpetuate coloniality.

Keywords: decolonial methodology · research questions · positionality · urban planning · Global South

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Introduction

For centuries, colonialism and imperialism have functioned as forms of spatial organisation at both global and local scales (King, 1989), leaving legacies that persist today and continue to shape major urban challenges. Contemporary efforts to address social (Oyewùmí, 2011; Bonnett, 2002; Stam and Spence, 1983) and environmental injustices (Adger et al., 2001; Gilberthorpe and Rajak, 2017) in cities, through urban planning and environmental management, can frequently be traced back to colonial and neo-colonial practices (Ha and Schneider, 2016; Zwischenraum Kollektiv, 2017). These practices commonly privilege infrastructure-led solutions and adopt an extractivist worldview. Grounded in the presumed universality of knowledge production (Said, 1978), contemporary city-making tends to disregard the social, temporal, and spatial continuities and ruptures of colonial legacies, leading to reductive generalisations of "non-Western" urban forms (cf. Bishop et al., 2003; King, 2004; McFarlane, 2006a; Robinson, 2006) that erase the "other" from the production of cities (Bhambra, 2014). Decolonial thinking calls for actively disentangling Eurocentric ideas, knowledge, and beliefs, while also reclaiming the languages, social organisations, memories, economies, and lands that were subsumed by colonialism (Bhambra, 2014; Mignolo, 2011) and enabling researchers to engage with "Other(ed)" ways of knowing (Thambinathan and Kinsela, 2021).

In *Decolonising Methodologies: Research and Indigenous Peoples*, Linda Tuhiwai Smith (1999) raises fundamental questions about the role and impact of academic research, emphasising the deep fatigue among Indigenous peoples who have been historically overstudied without seeing their lives improve as a result. For many Indigenous communities, she notes, "the term 'research' is inextricably linked to European imperialism and colonialism," and it remains bound to the "collective memory of imperialism" (Smith, 1999, p. 1). In many instances, such research merely confirms "things already known," proposes solutions that will not work, and serves primarily to advance the careers of those who already hold academic privilege (Smith, 1999, p. 3). As a result, communities increasingly resist being treated as "objects of research," pointing out that despite the abundance of academic studies, their lived conditions have not changed proportionally.

In urban research, especially when studying the Global South from both within and outside, the tension between what counts as "valid" or "valuable" knowledge and what is dismissed as invalid or unscientific becomes evident. One manifestation of this is the recurring academic focus on the "slum" as an object of analysis in work addressing social struggles. The authors of this essay have conducted studies in slums to expose precarious living conditions (see Table 1), critique urban planning for excluding these areas from the city, and highlight existing social dynamics that challenge hegemonic solutions such as eviction and relocation.

Yet in some contexts, Brazil being a notable example, slum residents are also fatigued by repeated research that brings little tangible improvement. In Rio de Janeiro, the

collective *What and for Whom Does Favela Research Serve?* challenges the prevailing relationship between universities and favelas. One of its founders, Fransérgio Goulart de Oliveira Silva, explains that the group emerged in response to growing discomfort among favela residents at being treated as "mere objects" rather than recognised as knowledge producers (*A favela e as pesquisas acadêmicas*, 2019). The group also criticises the common practice of outside researchers failing to return to share their findings with the community, and, like Tuhiwai Smith, it questions the assumption that research inherently does good. They pose an unsettling question: "Why do they only research oppressed people, instead of understanding that many of their privileges oppress us?" (Oliveira Silva, 2019).

Engaging in critical reflexivity (Allen, 2018) and drawing on a literature review of decolonial methodologies and critical urban planning, we approach the book's proposed aspects of decolonial methodological learning, namely theory, practice, and politics, through the challenges that precede the definition of methodology: epistemological assumptions, researcher positionality, and the framing of research questions. On the latter, we reflect first on who researches and how, and second on what and when research is undertaken. From a decolonial standpoint, as the book suggests, this requires unpacking research conceptualisation, which often precedes and informs methodology, thereby embracing the research process in its entirety. Such an approach compels us to confront the power dynamics ingrained in academia, to challenge entrenched hierarchies of knowledge that reproduce coloniality (Castro-Gómez, 2007), and to create spaces where the persistence of Eurocentric research paradigms can be contested, making room for alternative paradigms constructed through "worlds and knowledges otherwise" (Escobar, 2007, 179).

We address issues of epistemological theory while bringing practice and politics from our own experiences of conducting research in the Global South. To date, few reflexive and critical works on methodologies have facilitated dialogue among researchers working across distinct contexts and research environments. The reflections emerging from our shared struggles in the field reveal that the challenges and personal discomfort we encounter are not isolated but rather embedded within broader structural systems of power that must be critically engaged with. To illustrate this, we present vignettes from our past and present research, contextualised and systematised in Table 1.

Table 1. Research Project Details

Researcher	Time-frame	Research Context(s)	Policy Relevance	Partnerships	Funding Agencies
R1	2011–present	India, Mexico, South Africa, Turkey, Tanzania, Bangladesh	Yes	Universities, research organisations, NGOs, local authorities and citizens	Royal Academy of Engineering, UK Research and Innovation Council, British Council, Newton Fund
R2	2011–present	Brazil and South Africa	Yes	Universities, research organisations, civil society, local governmental institutions	Brazilian government, National Research Council (EU country).
R3	2011–present	Brazil and Peru	Yes	Universities, civil society, governmental institutions	Brazilian Government, European Union and International cooperation agencies.
R4	2011–present	India, South Africa and Kenya	Yes	Universities, research organisations, local and national government, civil society, and the private sector.	European Union, Government of India, National Research Council (EU country).

Source: Authors

This chapter is organised into four parts: first, we critique existing urban planning theories by engaging post-colonial research in dialogue with decolonial premises and related research practices; second, we examine researcher positionality and research design, highlighting systemic issues through a decolonial lens grounded in our own experiences; third, we consider research topics and their implications for participation fatigue and research impact, critically reflecting on our encounters in the field; and finally, we address the structural constraints that shape efforts to adopt a decolonial perspective in urban planning research in the Global South, emphasising the importance of raising 'uncomfortable' questions throughout the research process.

A Critique from the South: Urban Planning Theory and Research

Over the last decade, urban studies have entered a new phase that critically interrogates the dominance of the Global North in theorising and understanding cities (Robinson, 2006; Roy, 2011). Traditionally, urban scholarship has relied on geographical distinctions to frame the analysis and theorisation of cities. Global cities, largely located in the North, are typically portrayed as "command-and-control nodes of the global economy," whereas cities in the Global South are classified as "megacities, big but powerless" (Roy, 2011, p. 308). These megacities are equated with "underdevelopment," and characterised by "poverty, disease, violence, and toxicity" (Roy, 2011, p. 308).

This framing persists even though much of the urban growth in the coming decades is projected to occur in the rapidly expanding towns and cities of the South. Postcolonial urban theory, however, is frequently trivialised and dismissed, its historical urban

development trajectories overlooked, and the specificity of places such as Rio de Janeiro, Kinshasa, or Mumbai reduced to mere "empirical variation" (Roy, 2012). While urbanisation is undeniably a global process, collapsing all cities into a single framework erases their specificities and reinforces the Eurocentrism of urban studies, where Europe remains the reference point (Roy, 2012).

Recent scholarship on shifting geographies of urbanisation and postcolonial critique has questioned the treatment of cities in the Global South as "mere variations of a universal urban form," tied to the Euro-American legacy of urban studies (Robinson and Roy, 2015; Ruddick et al., 2017; Goonewardena, 2018). The postcolonial critique has sought to revitalise comparative urbanism as a means of democratising knowledge (Robinson, 2011; Roy and Ong, 2011). One promising approach is the adoption of "translational methodologies," where research is collaboratively designed and conducted with the explicit aim of producing knowledge that not only explains urban change but also informs transformative action (Parnell and Pieterse, 2015, p. 239).

Parnell and Robinson (2013, p. 596) emphasise that "traditional structures of knowledge production, characterised by an unequal distribution of scholars and research resources across the world of cities," grant disproportionate visibility to certain theoretical frameworks, while leaving others underdeveloped. As they argue, theories that work well in the Global North, such as urban regime analysis, accounts of gentrification, critiques of neoliberal urbanism, or formal urban renewal processes, are uncritically mobilised to interpret contexts where these processes are secondary, intersect with different drivers of change, or may not apply at all (Roy, 2012). This reflection highlights how the location from which knowledge is produced influences theory-building and its relevance to the South.

While postcolonial urban scholarship has presented extensive critiques of Eurocentric and modern/colonial modes of knowledge, engaging it in dialogue with decolonial theory and methodologies opens the possibility of moving beyond critique to reframe questions and think otherwise. Yet this shift is not straightforward. Coloniality (Maldonado-Torres, 2016) is deeply embedded in the ways we have been trained to think and perceive the world. Attempts to decolonise without first understanding how colonial categories continue to structure our thought can risk reproducing the very logic they seek to dismantle.

For example, categories such as race and gender remain indispensable for critique. Decolonial feminism, in particular, has exposed how non-white women have been constructed as both victims of patriarchy and inherently powerless (Curiel, 2009; Espinosa-Miñoso, 2014; Lugones, 2008), while also revealing the Eurocentrism and marginalisation of gender within established urban theory (Peake, 2018; Roy, 2015). By challenging universalised categories, decolonial feminists have not only radicalised critique but also generated alternative genealogies of women's struggles, collective, communal, and grounded at the borders of institutions and hegemonic knowledge

production (Curiel, 2009). Black feminists further argue that in the modern/colonial logic, class has always been racialised and gendered, underscoring the need to account for intersecting modes of power (Collins, 2000).

A decolonial methodological approach, therefore, requires a process of unlearning: unsettling ingrained assumptions so we may ask different questions. First, it demands rejecting the idea of universal "best practices" that homogenise diverse experiences in the Global South. Second, it compels researchers to recognise that colonisation, though global in reach, is always historically situated. Rather than retreating into local exceptionalism, this requires acknowledging that colonial differences, whether racial, gendered, or class-based, are contextually produced through particular interpretations and impositions of meaning (da Silva, 1998). While Goldberg (2014) highlights that exclusionary practices in one place shape and reinforce those elsewhere, and Quijano (2000) identifies a global pattern of racialisation, this does not absolve us from engaging with the specific histories of exclusion within each context. To do otherwise risks reproducing generalisations that obscure local struggles.

Equally important is recognising that colonised people lived, and continue to live, through diverse ontologies and understandings of what constitutes a "better life" and how space is constructed. These ways of being, erased or marginalised, must be foregrounded when studying local trajectories of subjugation and resistance. Decolonial scholarship has begun to recover these ontologies, such as *ubuntu*, *bizoidade* (Malomalo, 2018), *sumak kawsay* (Espinosa-Miñoso et al., 2014), and *quilombismo* (Afolabi, 2012), which offer modes of reading the world beyond the modern/individualist/capitalist axis. They embody both utopia and praxis, rooted in lived experience. This requires rejecting modern categories of universality or totality (Santos, 2002), which have historically elevated Eurocentric knowledge as universal while dismissing knowledge produced in the South as provincial or illegitimate (Chakrabarty, 2008; Mignolo, 2003; Wynter, 2003).

Yet, even progressive research remains framed within the epistemological logic of modernity/coloniality. As Dussel (2006, p. 491) notes, many scholars in formerly colonised contexts consider themselves critical thinkers, yet rarely acknowledge the extent of their Eurocentrism. Overcoming this is especially difficult given that higher education worldwide continues to operate through Eurocentric structures of research organisation, funding, evaluation, and metrics. Even where alternatives emerge, they remain entangled with these systems. Debates on decolonising the university have highlighted the challenges of transforming institutions that increasingly operate as capitalist enterprises, governed by disciplinarism, corporatism, and performance metrics (Castro-Gómez, 2007). Proposed solutions, such as dissolving hierarchies of knowledge in a "transcultural university" (Castro-Gómez, 2007) or reimagining a "pluriversity" ('A favela e as pesquisas acadêmicas,' 2019), point toward promising directions, but also raise a difficult question: within the structures of global capitalism and entrenched coloniality, is such transformation truly possible?

Beyond Critical Reflexivity: Who Researches and How?

The first set of reflections we present for advancing decolonial methodological learning concerns the formulation of research questions and, importantly, who formulates them. Drawing on our experiences across diverse research contexts and in dialogue with literature on decolonial methodologies, we engage critically with the theoretical, practical, and political dimensions of knowledge production. We aim to show how decolonial methods can disrupt and reconfigure traditional approaches. Table 1 outlines the scope of each author's research experience, which serves as the basis for these reflections. To ensure anonymity, project details have been generalised, and the order of presentation does not correspond to the chapter's authorship. The information provided highlights the multiple and intersecting interests shaping research that is often framed as policy-relevant, such as slum upgrading initiatives, waste management, urban design, and participatory planning, undertaken in collaboration with financial institutions and across different national contexts over the past decade.

Critical reflexivity has long been a central concern in postcolonial, feminist, and critical race studies, emphasising the need to re-examine the relationship between researchers and those they research. In the social sciences, Allen (2018, p. 990) underscores the importance of recognising both the "inter-subjective positionality of social researchers within the field" and the "objective positionality that a researcher carries with them into the field." Such positionality is never fixed; it shifts, consciously or unconsciously, as researchers navigate insider-outsider dynamics while balancing their own backgrounds with the research context. Yet this constant negotiation unfolds within uneven power relations, where the academic privilege of critical interpretation elevates scholarly narratives above other forms of knowledge production.

This privilege is sustained through the reproduction of a colonial matrix of power (Mignolo, 2007, building on Quijano), in which the control of subjectivity and knowledge is a key pillar. As Escobar (2007, p. 201) argues, this control is embedded in a "Eurocentred and Eurocentric notion of modernity" that defines the geopolitics of knowledge production. Quijano (2007, p. 174) further notes that the European paradigm of rational knowledge was developed as part of a broader colonial power structure, expressing its "coloniality" through the imposition of Western methodologies, ontologies, and epistemologies. These frameworks, originally designed to dominate and exploit (Waldueller, 2015), continue to shape contemporary definitions of what counts as 'good research,' thereby constraining efforts to adopt decolonial perspectives.

Such logics are deeply embedded not only in planning and development agendas but also in popular understandings of what "progress" means. In my own work on urban planning in Indian cities, I grappled with the challenge that participants and stakeholders, deeply conditioned by colonial attitudes, viewed a decolonial lens as inappropriate or ineffective.

This created systemic barriers to research, making it difficult to address urban issues through frameworks not aligned with colonial legacies. (R1)

Linda Smith (1999, p. 2) challenges the assumption that research inherently serves the public good, framing this belief as an ideological construct of academic training. She warns that such assumptions risk reproducing colonial practices, particularly when researchers unconsciously adopt a 'teaching' role in community engagement. These dynamics extend beyond the classic outsider–insider divide (e.g., white researchers studying racialised groups, or urban middle classes studying rural communities) and can also surface in insider–insider contexts.

During my PhD research with a marginalised rural community in my own country, I was cast as an "outside saviour", a white, urban researcher from the capital who could supposedly help alleviate poverty. Despite my attempts to clarify my role, I was invited on stage during a public event and thanked for my work in a way that reinforced this perception. The experience revealed how my research design itself, shaped by academic structures, positioned me within power relations I could not escape. In hindsight, I recognise that disclaimers about power asymmetries were insufficient; participants could not easily opt out, and my limited awareness as an inexperienced researcher meant I reproduced the very dynamics I sought to critique. (R2)

Such experiences illustrate that even when research feels "wrong," researchers may lack the tools to act otherwise. These dilemmas highlight the need to view reflexivity not merely as individual positioning but as part of a broader critique of research processes (Allen, 2005). Urban research, in particular, intertwines with the performativity of planning and is judged by its real-world impact. Yet, as Allen (2005, p. 991, emphasis in original) notes, researchers are subject to the "disciplinary gaze" of academia, becoming "docile researchers" whose work is shaped by the expectations of funders and institutions. Since much socially transformative research is publicly funded, researchers also face contradictions arising from the colonial-capitalist state's historical conflicts with Indigenous and colonised communities (Zavala, 2013, p. 66). On a global scale, large funding bodies reproduce extractivist politics of knowledge production, shaping research agendas to align with national or institutional priorities (Noxolo, 2017). This creates an "unreflective approach to the social production of knowledge" (Allen, 2005, p. 996) and risks diluting the transformative potential of decolonial work, recentering privilege within academic structures (Esson et al., 2017, p. 385).

The uneven distribution of research funding also perpetuates a division of labour where postcolonial regions provide raw data while metropolitan institutions monopolise theorisation (Comaroff and Comaroff, 2012; Connell, 2014). As researchers currently employed in European universities but shaped by our experiences in the Global South, we often find ourselves reproducing modes of knowledge production that marginalise difference and normalise Eurocentric academic practices (Silva et al., 2020, p. 504).

For instance, before my research was judged by its substance, I was perceived through my institutional affiliation with the University of Amsterdam and my participation in an EU-funded project. Although this gave me access to certain state and non-state actors in Chennai, it also marked me as an outsider. A local researcher once remarked, "You people come here, do the research, and write about Chennai. So we end up reading about our own city from outsiders." My institutional positioning, combined with being North Indian, distanced me from the very communities I studied in my own country. (R4)

Yet privilege can also create unexpected opportunities to amplify marginalised struggles.

While researching public policies for Afrodescendants in Peru, my position as an antiracist activist allowed me to connect with the topic, though I remained an outsider by nationality and limited familiarity with local racial dynamics. At times, I was seen as a European researcher by virtue of my institutional affiliation. When I asked activists what my research could contribute, one responded bluntly: "Nothing." Another suggested that our privilege gave us access to government officials who ignored grassroots voices, making our work useful in amplifying their long-standing critiques. Though this dynamic was profoundly uncomfortable, it highlighted how research can strategically leverage privilege while also reinforcing structural inequities. (R3)

Taken together, these experiences underscore the complex implications of insider-outsider positionalities in decolonial research. While feminist and postcolonial traditions emphasise situating oneself within power structures, the decolonial turn pushes further, urging us to interrogate the unevenness of knowledge production itself. This requires scrutinising the epistemic privileges and theoretical alliances that reproduce whiteness (Tîstea, 2020, p. 26) while acknowledging our shared responsibility in engaging with marginalised groups. Ultimately, such reflexivity invites us to recognise that our own research practices are not external to modernity but deeply shaped by it. In the next section, we turn to the equally crucial question of how research questions themselves are defined.

The Research Questions: When and What?

In this section, we turn to a second set of reflections on decolonising research methods by interrogating what is being researched, when, and under whose terms. Context-based research is deeply shaped by politics: whose temporalities does research attend to, and whose interests frame the questions being asked? When working with marginalised groups, further questions arise: what role do they play in shaping methodologies, setting priorities, and defining the scope of projects?

The very notion of "fieldwork" has been problematised (Nhemachena et al., 2016) for its extractivist roots: treating communities as repositories of raw data while reproducing

systems of domination. Although the term "research subjects" has largely been replaced by "participants" to signal greater engagement, in practice, research processes remain unchanged. Communities are usually consulted late, positioned as samples within pre-defined frameworks, which produces several problems: research fatigue, unequal distribution of benefits, and unintended local consequences.

In Brazil, resistance to research is growing, particularly among activists and "trendy" communities that have long been over-studied. Beyond fatigue, there is a growing recognition that academic production rarely aligns with community agendas. One interviewee in Brazil expressed her refusal to participate in projects disconnected from her people's struggles:

I think research has to be related to the agendas that the movement is proposing... I no longer want to participate in research that is exclusively in the interest of the researcher... I only give an interview today if I think that what I'm going to say has some connection with the struggle of my people anywhere in the world. If not, I won't do it... First, we need to be alive, you know? The research must be related to the life of the subject being discussed, rather than just the interests that the researcher brings to the table with their preconceived notions.

Her frustration also pointed to the narrow ways in which concepts such as "organisation" are judged by outsiders. Communities that have survived for centuries are dismissed as "unorganised" when they do not conform to externally imposed categories. This critique was sharpened by her comparison with a recent NGO-led study on racist violence against *quilombo* communities, research intentionally designed outside the university and directly aligned with grassroots struggles. Her case underscores Linda Tuhiwai Smith's (1999) point that research is indeed needed, but that design and priorities are too often disconnected from community-defined concerns.

A similar dynamic appeared in research on informal settlements in India. Here, participants would ask, "What will happen with this study?" Researchers explained their roles, secured informed consent, and clarified participants' right to withdraw. Yet, the relationship remained one-sided: the project addressed issues identified by the researchers, not residents. While co-creation methods sought to centre participants in agenda-setting, these proved uncomfortable. Residents, over-researched yet unfamiliar with problem-structuring approaches, preferred more traditional workshop formats. Critical questions, such as *Who owns the research? Whose interests does it serve? Who decides what counts as a problem?* were difficult to sustain. (R4)

Critical reflection on participatory action research can offer insightful perspectives on these questions. Kisa Nygreen (2009) observes that "it is always tricky for an individual to initiate a project and expect others to take it on as their own" (p. 19). She further notes that this issue becomes "especially problematic when the initiator is an outsider to the community, while also occupying multiple positions of power in relation to other participants," or when "the initiator is clearly and disproportionately benefiting from the

project (such as by earning a doctoral degree), funding it, legitimising it, and holding it together" (Nygreen, 2009, p. 19).

Claims to "equal ownership" may mask structural asymmetries, producing what she calls "false egalitarianism", benignly patronising at best, oppressive at worst. Methodologies cannot fully equalise power in societies shaped by entrenched oppressions. Acknowledging these limits is crucial to avoid reproducing domination under the guise of progressive tools.

Another unresolved issue concerns the delivery of results. Participatory methodology debates emphasise how to return findings in accessible formats (Vaughn and Jacquez, 2020). Yet the question is less about format than about relevance: do results genuinely engage with ongoing struggles, or do they simply circulate back as another layer of academic production? For example, should slum residents, already overburdened with precarious labour and family responsibilities, be asked to dedicate time to documenting infrastructural deficits that are obvious to them? If so, can they be acknowledged as knowledge producers, sharing the survival strategies and "technologies" they deploy daily? And, crucially, do they even want to share these practices with outsiders?

Another case from Brazil illustrates the ambiguities. While studying the impacts of slum upgrading projects that caused mass evictions, researchers encountered no resistance: residents were eager to document grievances against municipal authorities. Reports of cracks in new buildings, structural damage, and disrespectful treatment flowed freely. Researchers expressed solidarity, took photographs, and produced detailed accounts. Yet this interaction also generated expectations of intervention that researchers could not fulfil. Although the final reports were submitted to the District Attorney and later informed a class-action lawsuit, the dissonance between residents' urgent needs and the researchers' limited capacity left lasting unease. As one of us reflects, "Even after so many years, I feel haunted by this research interaction and how we promised things we could never deliver." (R3)

These examples highlight the tension between research timelines (dictated by funding cycles, project deadlines, and publication schedules) and political temporalities (defined by ongoing struggles for land, housing, or recognition). Decolonial reflections remind us that decoloniality is not only a theory but also a praxis (Dulci and Malheiros, 2021). This means asking whether researchers can commit to struggles whose timeframes extend far beyond academic projects. Can contributions be made when they matter most for communities, rather than when it suits research agendas? And if our involvement is necessarily limited, can we be honest about the size and scale of our contributions?

Discussing Future Directions

This chapter examines research priorities in urban planning by asking how research questions are formulated, by whom, what kinds of questions are pursued, and the temporalities that shape them. Drawing on our own experiences alongside the literature on decolonial methodologies, we reflect on whether our research priorities have aligned with those of the communities we study, challenging ourselves to shift the "gaze." For example, moving the focus away from "slums" toward white-segregated areas, or the racialised, gendered, and class-based dynamics of investment and disinvestment across the city, can reveal colonial logics of property protection, titling, and patterns of dispossession. Even when working in "slums," the challenge remains: how do we move beyond researching *with* communities to genuinely recognising participants as producers of knowledge? Where do we situate ourselves within these debates, and how can reflection on positionality shape the questions we ask and the designs we adopt? Such considerations highlight that a decolonial turn in research requires reflexivity not only during "fieldwork" (see Berger, 2015; Ergun and Edmir, 2010; Milligan, 2016; Noh, 2019; Saharan et al., 2021; Siwale, 2015), but across the entire process of research design.

Interrogating epistemological assumptions must also move beyond "confessions of privilege" (Lockard in Thambinathan and Kinsella, 2021), which frequently allow researchers to avoid actively engaging with colonial legacies. Instead, the decolonial turn compels us to examine the structures that reproduce the historical division of labour in knowledge production, where the postcolony supplies raw data and the metropole produces theory (Comaroff and Comaroff, 2015; Connell, 2014). From this perspective, reflexivity cannot be treated merely as an individual practice; it must be understood as embedded in broader systems of power, including the university itself.

Recognising that social struggles are entangled with larger patterns of oppression also raises the question: must we always focus on marginalised communities? Current academic norms push researchers toward collaboration and civil society engagement, but this can translate into additional pressure on marginalised groups. When is it truly necessary to work with communities, whether within our own countries or abroad, where we may be outsiders? How do we build conceptual frameworks that avoid reproducing burdens of extraction? And when should we leverage our own privilege to examine non-marginalised groups that are equally implicated in the reproduction of inequalities?

As Linda Tuhiwai Smith reminds us, the first step toward decolonial research for the Maori was "determining as Maori our own research needs and priorities" (Smith, 1999, p. 196). Framing research questions, then, is itself a decisive moment in dismantling the subject-object dichotomy. Yet this step must also be accompanied by a refusal to impose pre-conceived models of "better" living conditions or "better" social organisation, which tend to be shaped by racist, sexist, and Eurocentric hierarchies of superiority and inferiority. These assumptions can easily infiltrate urban development policies and research on the "urban poor" in postcolonial contexts. While methodological innovation in

community participation may generate co-creative solutions, reframing research questions is not only about improving participation. It is also about shifting perspectives, reframing problems from different angles, and, at times, searching for answers in entirely different places.

Conclusion

In this chapter, we have drawn from our experiences as researchers from the Global South working within Northern universities to reflect on the challenges and opportunities, both theoretical and practical, of conducting research from a decolonial standpoint. We highlighted how postcolonial planning scholarship has opened critical debates on knowledge production, and we argued that planning research gains considerably when engaging with decolonial theory and praxis. In particular, we emphasised that colonial categories of gender, race, and class must be understood through the situated histories of oppression and resistance embedded in local and regional contexts. Exploring decolonial methodologies thus requires a process of unlearning and unsettling the assumptions we have been taught to reproduce.

Engaging in a reflexive process, especially around how research questions are formulated, can empower researchers by sharpening their awareness of responsibility. Reflexivity also compels us to confront the ethical and epistemological challenges of decolonising research practices. This includes not only questioning our research choices but also confronting the structural conditions of the university that push us to reproduce oppressive logics as a means of academic survival. We are called upon to value slum residents and marginalised groups as knowledge producers, yet we are rarely taught how to do so. As Sabelo Ndlovu-Gatsheni (2019) reminds us, to decolonise research, we must also decolonise research education itself. Methodology, as it is traditionally taught, remains a "technology of sustenance of Eurocentric knowledge," foreclosing "any attempt to know otherwise than what is already laid down as legitimate ways of knowing" (p. 490). Nevertheless, students are still expected to present a clear methodology a priori, prescribing how new knowledge is to be discovered, thereby reproducing the same epistemic limits.

Researchers, whether in the North or South, continue to be trained within institutions where coloniality is entrenched and rationality is narrowly defined. While our reflections emphasise that the problem is structural, addressing it begins with individual moments of awakening that disrupt inherited ways of thinking. Yet such awakenings, on their own, remain insufficient if the structural foundations of research and higher education are left unchallenged. Efforts to decolonise the university remain sporadic, fragmented, and incomplete (Mbembe, 2016). Moreover, as Esson et al. (2017) caution, decolonial scholarship itself risks being appropriated in ways that dilute its disruptive potential, transforming it into a comfortable discourse that no longer unsettles colonial/modern

institutions. If everyone feels too comfortable engaging with "decoloniality" within academic spaces, perhaps it is because it has ceased to be truly decolonial.

To take a decolonial standpoint in research, therefore, requires more than reflexivity; it demands developing new languages of inquiry capable of situating colonial and hegemonic narratives and exposing their implications. Urban planning, itself a colonial discipline, presents obvious obstacles to decolonial research. Yet it also provides a unique opportunity: precisely because of its historical entanglements with colonial power, it avails fertile ground for imagining and constructing pathways toward decolonial methodologies that unsettle, resist, and ultimately transform knowledge production.

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Chapter 6

Indigenising Research Practices: Prospects of Incorporating Indigenous African Culture into Research

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Abstract

This chapter explores ways of systemising research practices in Africa by centring Indigenous African culture and knowledge systems. Historically, research in Africa has been shaped and dominated by Western epistemologies, ontologies, and axiologies, which have consistently devalued Indigenous ways of knowing. This has perpetuated the marginalisation of African cultural knowledge within scholarly and policy communities. We argue for a shift from the narrow Eurocentric lens traditionally applied to African issues towards the adoption of indigenised research methodologies and tools. Such an approach presents a counter-narrative to the Eurocentric expropriation of knowledge, contributing to the decolonisation and regeneration of African cultures and enabling self-reliance in knowledge production. We propose reconceptualising research strategies in ways that embrace the complementarity of Indigenous and contemporary approaches, thereby generating research processes and recommendations grounded in African contexts and worldviews. Drawing inspiration from Linda Tuhiwai Smith's Indigenous principles, this chapter discusses practical decolonising strategies for research in Africa that reflect Indigenous African values, epistemologies, and orientations.

Keywords: Indigenous culture · Decolonising methodologies · Marginalisation · Research methodologies

Background

Researchers are entrusted with the responsibility to cause no harm, yet research has been a source of distress for Indigenous peoples due to inappropriate methods and exploitative practices (Cochran et al., 2008). Research is never neutral; it takes place within socio-political contexts where power and interests are at stake (Smith, 2012). Historically, what has been at stake is the dignity and rights of entire groups. Early colonial projects were legitimised by disciplines such as anthropology and eugenics, which produced so-called "truths" about colonised peoples, truths that were externally imposed, rooted in prejudice, and built upon incomplete or distorted information (Smith, 2012). Such research did not reflect the lived realities of Indigenous and colonised peoples, but rather reinforced the self-image of colonising societies (Said, 1978).

Research on Indigenous peoples has therefore unfolded in contexts where colonial governments and institutions have denied both histories and the ongoing legacies of colonisation and genocide. Within this framework, the Western researcher has been

positioned as the authority on Indigenous lives, effectively denying communities the right to self-representation. Knowledge produced through these processes constructs reductive images of the "Other," which are then reproduced in the media, education, official histories, and political policies (Smith, 2012). A striking example can be found in Canada's residential school system. For generations, Indigenous elders testified to the abuse and deaths of children in these schools and called for site assessments. Yet this community knowledge was dismissed until the recent discoveries of mass graves, which finally forced recognition of these truths by the state. This illustrates how official research silences Indigenous voices and shows how the politics of whose histories are validated directly shape public understandings of justice, reconciliation, and ethical intergroup relations.

Many researchers assume their work is inherently beneficial, but such a self-image, when unexamined, can itself be harmful. The belief that research automatically serves a "greater good" is ideological and contradicts Indigenous experiences of research (Smith, 2012). Universities have increasingly been called out for extracting knowledge from Indigenous communities without building lasting relationships or ensuring benefits for those communities. Research has frequently advanced the careers of external scholars while offering little value to Indigenous peoples themselves, reproducing extractive and unilateral colonial dynamics (McGregor, 2018). This has prompted Indigenous communities to demand accountability on critical questions: Who owns the research? Who benefits from it? What will happen to the findings? (Smith, 2012).

The way research questions are framed is central to whether they reinforce harmful narratives. Too often, Western researchers have highlighted "problems" in Indigenous communities without situating them in the broader contexts of colonialism, cultural genocide, and intergenerational trauma. This decontextualisation risks portraying social challenges as inherent flaws of Indigenous groups, pathologising them as "at risk" or "vulnerable" in ways that naturalise risk as an internal trait rather than the product of systemic oppression (Chambers et al., 2018).

Beyond framing, Western methodologies for evaluating and synthesising research have also been critiqued for sidelining Indigenous worldviews. Battiste (2013) underscores that dominant research approaches fail to recognise Indigenous ways of knowing. For instance, systematic reviews and meta-analyses, methods used to identify so-called "evidence-based practices" (EBPs), rely exclusively on published, Western-centric literature. These frameworks privilege written over oral traditions, empirical over traditional inquiry, and quantitative over qualitative or community-based methods (Chambers et al., 2018). While EBPs are presented as objective, they are in fact grounded in epistemological hierarchies that elevate logical positivism and delegitimise other worldviews.

Research in Africa

Research in Africa has long been dominated by Euro-Western epistemologies and methodologies that marginalise, exclude, and devalue the cultural and spiritual realities of African societies (McDonnell, 2013). Much of the research undertaken on the continent has followed frameworks and practices that privilege Western ways of knowing, with little room for integrating the social, cultural, and spiritual dimensions that are central to Indigenous African worldviews.

This reliance on Western epistemologies has effectively relegated Indigenous African knowledge systems to the margins. As Lebakeng (2010) argues, the dominance of Western approaches has pushed aside valuable cultural, social, and spiritual resources that are essential for the well-being and sustainable development of African communities. Fields as diverse as the humanities, physical sciences, arts, and medical sciences across Africa have largely been shaped by epistemological traditions that remain alien to local contexts (Keikelame and Swartz, 2019).

Although Western science has undoubtedly contributed positively in areas such as medicine, its over-application in African research has also had deleterious consequences. Studies conducted under Eurocentric paradigms fail to address the lived realities of Indigenous peoples, as they inadequately incorporate cultural and social contexts or respond to the specific needs of communities (Keikelame and Swartz, 2019). As a result, outcomes frequently lack relevance and applicability within African settings.

This disconnect arises in part from the fact that the socio-cultural and spiritual contexts of Western societies differ profoundly from those of the Global South. Uncritically importing Western methodologies into Africa thus risks producing knowledge that has limited resonance or utility for local realities. Overreliance on such approaches not only undermines the production of local knowledge but also perpetuates forms of epistemic oppression, producing "truths" that do not adequately reflect African lived experiences.

Decolonising methodologies

Research institutions are increasingly acknowledging Indigenous peoples' concerns about how they have historically been treated by Western researchers. In response, some scholars, particularly Indigenous researchers themselves, have incorporated decolonising methodologies into their work to ensure cultural responsiveness and respect for the communities who participate in, conduct, or are affected by research (Dillard, 2012; Smith, 2012).

Traditional research methodologies that marginalise Indigenous knowledge inevitably reproduce colonial relations. Decolonial methodologies, therefore, require critical self-reflexivity about how research might perpetuate colonial dynamics. True

decolonisation demands that Indigenous knowledge, theories, and worldviews serve as the foundation, not merely an add-on, for research. This shift affects all stages of the research process: framing questions, selecting data collection methods, analysing results, and presenting findings must all centre Indigenous and Afrocentric ways of knowing. As Kovach (2009) argues, decolonial methodologies are not adaptations of Western methods but emerge from tribal epistemologies and Indigenous philosophies. They treat Indigenous knowledge as a legitimate, autonomous system upon which research designs, protocols, and methods can be built.

In practice, this might involve framing studies around traditional knowledge systems, legitimising oral traditions as primary sources, operationalising research constructs (e.g., health, well-being) in culturally specific ways, and promoting holistic approaches in domains such as medicine, social sciences, and environmental research (Chambers et al., 2018). Decolonial methodologies also contextualise research within broader histories of imperialism, racism, and colonial domination, demanding critical reflexivity about the positionality of the researcher (McGregor, 2018). Importantly, they are grounded in Indigenous self-determination, rejecting claims of neutrality and explicitly advocating for historical justice (Tuck and Yang, 2012).

Smith (2012) emphasises that Indigenous research is organised around projects of reclamation, healing, and cultural restoration. These projects are diverse, yet interconnected, and they collectively work toward self-determination. In line with principles of self-representation, decolonising methodologies prioritise research *with* communities rather than *on* them. This involves developing long-term relationships with families and communities, co-creating research designs, jointly interpreting findings, and sharing knowledge in ways that extend beyond one-time presentations of results. Here, knowledge sharing is dialogical; researchers and community members engage in discussions about the frameworks and theories that shape the interpretation of data long before conclusions are presented.

In Africa, decolonising research has particular relevance for land claims and Indigenous sovereignty. Land disputes require communities to document histories of territory, tribe, and family in ways legible to state tribunals or courts. This has spurred intensive local research to legitimise claims, while also generating rich repositories of Indigenous histories and cultural memory. In contexts where land and natural resources such as water remain sites of contestation, research rooted in Indigenous epistemologies can strengthen claims and foreground long-standing collective ownership practices disrupted by colonisation.

Testimonies are especially significant in these processes. As formal oral accounts, given under oath, they capture the lived experiences and perspectives of Indigenous peoples in ways that resonate with both community members and institutional audiences (Smith, 2012). In Africa, integrating such oral traditions into research is a powerful means of indigenising knowledge production. Oral accounts and histories, passed down through

elders and storytellers, remain vital cultural archives. They transmit values, beliefs, and memories across generations, serving as both immediate records and inherited legacies (Vasina, 1965; Turner, 1986; Alcantara, Lalonde and Wilson, 2017).

For communities with limited access to written literacy, oral traditions are indispensable, providing the primary means of communication, documentation, and education. They constitute myths, folktales, legends, and historical narratives, which continue to shape collective memory. Increasingly, historians and ethnographers are recognising oral histories as authoritative sources, treating them as foundational rather than supplementary to written documentation (Henige, 1988; Rosenberg, 1987; Alcantara, Lalonde and Wilson, 2017).

Oral tradition remains the most valid and reliable source of historical knowledge in Indigenous African contexts, as much of Africa's history has been transmitted orally across generations. These traditions carry the knowledge, language, literature, and cultural resources of communities (Babatunde, 2015). They are not relics of the past but living traditions remembered through personal and collective experiences. Oral sources thus provide internally generated data that represent the ideologies, philosophies, worldviews, and histories of communities (Babatunde, 2015). As such, they must be recognised as history and knowledge in their own right, and treated on par with written records within decolonial research. By centring oral traditions, researchers can reach more authentic understandings of historical events and cultural practices (Babatunde, 2017). While Vansina (1965) affirms their legitimacy, oral traditions require careful, culturally sensitive handling. Researchers must possess deep knowledge of the language and culture of the communities they study to avoid misinterpretation (Babatunde, 2015).

One of the most important oral traditions in Africa is storytelling. Storytellers preserve and transmit the histories, beliefs, and values of communities to future generations. Storytelling provides a culturally appropriate way of representing diverse truths and lived realities. As a dialogical practice, it captures Indigenous voices more authentically than rigid Western research methods. Babatunde (2015) describes storytelling as an integrative cultural institution that embodies a society's wisdom, achievements, and values across politics, spirituality, health, and the arts. Storytelling, therefore, is not only a method of transmitting cultural heritage but also a methodology in its own right, one that aligns with Indigenous epistemologies and worldviews (Kovach, 2009; Tachine et al., 2016). It emphasises kinship, collective identity, and the concept of *we*—principles that underpin Indigenous ways of knowing (Archibald, 2008).

The principle of connectedness also underpins Indigenous methodologies. Locally created stories, songs, and folklore connect people to their environment, genealogies, and ancestral lands. They serve as reminders of cultural heritage and restore links disrupted by colonialism and assimilation (Smith, 2012). Grounding research in connectedness allows for a holistic understanding of human relationships with the environment and with cultural identity. By re-establishing these ties, decolonising methodologies help African

communities reclaim continuity with their heritage.

Another central principle is the celebration of survival. While colonial research emphasised cultural assimilation, decolonial approaches highlight Indigenous resilience and continuity. In Africa, survival is celebrated through music, festivals, rituals, and other communal practices that affirm cultural persistence. Such celebrations not only honour resistance to colonial domination but also foreground the resilience of Indigenous identities and communities (Smith, 2012).

Representation is equally vital. Historically, Indigenous Africans were denied opportunities to speak for themselves in both political and research contexts. Representation here has two dimensions: political participation and epistemic voice. Decolonising research requires that Indigenous people be included as researchers and knowledge producers rather than as mere subjects of study. Representation ensures that African cultural values, belief systems, and lived experiences are authentically reflected in knowledge production. Moreover, Indigenous researchers can draw upon their personal knowledge, cultural connections, and lived realities to generate insights that resonate with and benefit their communities.

Representation is also key to shaping policy and knowledge dissemination. African communities have long sought to envision their own futures and craft solutions to their challenges. Successful movements for language revitalisation, cultural resurgence, and community development demonstrate the power of collective representation grounded in Indigenous visions. Proverbs, stories, poems, and riddles, transmitted orally or inscribed in cultural artefacts, remain crucial vehicles of these visions, linking past wisdom with contemporary struggles.

Decolonising research also requires reclaiming control over the interpretation and application of knowledge. Western methodologies, applied uncritically, have contributed to the persistence of social problems by excluding Indigenous knowledge and failing to capture context-specific realities. Smith's (2012) principles of reframing and democratising research can help address these limitations by broadening participation and anchoring research in African traditions of communal living and collective responsibility.

Finally, decolonial methodologies demand a fundamentally different relationship with existing literature. Unlike Western approaches that treat prior scholarship as a foundation for new research, decolonial approaches remain cautious of reproducing colonial logics embedded in earlier works. Instead, they prioritise self-representation and Indigenous epistemologies as the most reliable sources of knowledge. In doing so, they shift the production of knowledge from a colonial framework toward one rooted in African voices, values, and lived experiences.

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This volume, *Reclaiming Knowledge: Decolonial Methodologies from the Global South*, reflects that commitment. The contributors come from Kenya, Ghana, Colombia, Brazil, Mexico, Belgium, Portugal, Sweden, the Netherlands, and the United Kingdom. They represent different stages of their careers and different disciplinary homes. What they share is the willingness to ask difficult questions about how knowledge is made and who it is made for.

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Research is never a neutral enterprise. Across history, it has functioned not only as a tool for discovery but also as an instrument of power, classification, and control. For much of Africa and the wider Global South, research has been entangled with colonial projects that privileged European epistemologies while devaluing or erasing Indigenous knowledge systems.

This volume brings together scholars from Kenya, Ghana, Colombia, Brazil, Mexico, Belgium, Portugal, Sweden, the Netherlands, and the United Kingdom to demonstrate, concretely, what research looks like when that inheritance is refused. Ubuntu philosophy, vivencias, participatory cartography, transformative learning, and indigenised social work practice: each represents an epistemological tradition with its own internal standards of validity and its own account of what research is for.

A vital contribution to the global conversation on knowledge sovereignty, decolonial practice, and the future of research from and for the Global South.

Ch.1 Ubuntu Philosophy & Decolonising Knowledge — Innocent & Adan

Ch.2 Vivencias: Knowledge Born from Struggle — Moreno-Cely

Ch.3 Cartographies from the South — Tarin & Sandroni

Ch.4 Women's Land Rights in Africa — Gyan & Chilliak

Ch.5 Decolonial Methodologies in Urban Planning — Coelho, Melgaço, Saharan & Rajendran

Ch.6 Indigenising Research Practices — Gyan, Yeboah, Abbey & Hervie

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